Immigrant Rights Expansion and Socio-Political Integration: Evidence from Italy

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Abstract

We study the effect of expanding immigrants' rights on their political and social integration. To do so, we exploit Romania's 2007 accession to the European Union (EU), which extended EU citizenship to Romanian immigrants in Italy and thereby strengthened their residency and local voting rights, even in the absence of Italian citizenship. Combining administrative and original municipality-level data with a continuous difference-in-differences design, we document three findings. (1) EU citizenship increased the election of Romanian-born councilors in municipalities with larger Romanian communities, with no comparable effect among non-enfranchised immigrant groups. Using an instrumental variable strategy, we show that the effect was driven by pre-2007 Romanian residents rather than new arrivals. Additional evidence suggests that it was driven by greater demand for Romanian-born candidates, as reflected in higher turnout among Romanians, rather than by greater candidate supply. (2) Consent to organ donation among Romanians increased after 2007, indicating that the effects of EU citizenship extended to prosocial behavior and strengthened attachment to the destination country. (3) Despite these integration gains, immigrant presence shifts municipal politics rightward, increases security spending, and reduces social spending regardless of whether the immigrant group holds EU citizenship, suggesting that any political influence of newly enfranchised EU citizens was insufficient to offset a persistent native backlash.

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1 Introduction

With a world population of migrants approaching 300 million (World Migration Report 2024), immigration is increasingly at the forefront of political debates. While scholars have long argued that free mobility of labor brings economic benefits, these benefits are often accompanied by negative social outcomes such as segregation and marginalization of immigrants (Bauder 2006), as well as political backlash and polarization.[1] It is therefore essential to understand what measures governments can implement to mitigate these negative effects, while preserving labor mobility.

Expanding immigrants' rights via naturalization substantially fosters integration (Bevelander and Pendakur 2011; Gathmann and Keller 2017; Hainmueller et al. 2017; Gathmann and Garbers 2023); however, naturalization is unlikely to provide a solution in the short and medium term. In most OECD countries, immigrants must reside for five to ten years before becoming eligible to apply for citizenship, making the process inherently lengthy. Moreover, naturalization reform is one of the most politically divisive issues, limiting prospects for accelerating the process. Finally, naturalization may impose significant personal costs on immigrants, including the renunciation of original citizenship or perceived threats to cultural identity (Dahl et al. 2022).

Several governments have thus adopted milder forms of expanding immigrant rights by granting voting and residency rights, implementing legalization programs, or creating forms of supranational citizenship. For instance, in some countries, non-citizen residents can vote in local or national elections. In the UK, Commonwealth citizens can vote in general elections and run for most political offices (Bhatiya 2025), while several US cities have enfranchised non-citizens in municipal elections. Some governments have also granted easier residency rights to foreign nationals. For example, under the MERCOSUR Residence Agreement, citizens of member and associated states can reside in another participating state with limited requirements and without a visa.[2] Another example is the use of legalization programs for undocumented immigrants. The 1986 U.S. Immigration Reform and Control Act (IRCA) granted permanent legal status to 2.8 million people (Casarico et al. 2018). EU enlargements have also expanded immigrants' voting and residency rights. Through EU citizenship, nationals of one member state who live in another gain the right to reside without a visa, as well as the right to vote and stand as candidates in local elections. Despite their prevalence, we have limited evidence on whether these milder forms of rights extension are effective.

This paper exploits Romania's accession to the European Union in 2007 (Mastrobuoni and Pinotti 2015) to study how the resulting expansion of residency and local voting rights for Romanians in Italy, through EU citizenship, affected their local political representation and prosocial behavior. It also investigates how these changes influenced the ideology of municipal governments

[1] See Hamilton and Whalley (1984); Clemens (2011); Kennan (2013); Foged et al. (2022) on economic benefits and Barone et al. (2016); Becker and Fetzer (2016); Halla et al. (2017); Viskanic (2017); Barrera et al. (2020); Tabellini (2020); Koukal et al. (2021); Mayda et al. (2022) on political backlash.

[2] The agreement provides for a two-year temporary residence permit that can subsequently be converted into permanent residence under very limited requirements. It applies not only to MERCOSUR member states (Argentina, Paraguay, Brazil, and Uruguay) but also to associated states, covering most of South America.

and municipal spending more broadly. To do so, we combine administrative and hand-collected electoral data on municipal elections with new data on consent to organ donation, by country of birth. Following Romania's accession to the European Union, Romanians - who constitute the largest immigrant community in Italy - gained the right to vote and stand in municipal elections, as well as stronger residency rights. We implement a continuous difference-in-differences analysis around 2007, where the pre-existing share of Romanians measures the intensity of treatment, as in Bernini et al. (2025), to estimate the effects of this expansion of rights on political outcomes. To isolate these effects from broader trends affecting immigrants more generally, we conduct placebo tests for other immigrant groups with a focus on Albanians and Moroccans, the two largest immigrant groups in Italy after Romanians, neither of whom gained EU citizenship. Together, these three groups account for approximately 40% of immigrants in Italy.[3]

Our first set of results shows an increase in Romanian representation after 2007 in Italian municipalities with larger Romanian populations. A municipality with a one-percentage-point higher share of Romanian residents in 2003 was 0.5 to 1 percentage point more likely to elect a Romanian-born councilor after 2007. We find no comparable increase in representation among Albanians, Moroccans or other immigrant groups who did not gain EU citizenship in 2007, suggesting that the results are not driven by general immigrant-related trends. These findings raise the question of whether the observed effects are attributable to long-term Romanian residents or to potentially endogenous post-2007 arrivals. To address this concern, we complement the analysis with an IV strategy. Specifically, we instrument the share of newly arrived Romanians with a combination of cross-sectoral demand for foreign labor in Italy and Romanian outflows to non-Italian destinations. We find that the effect is driven by Romanians who migrated to Italy prior to accession.

We then investigate the mechanisms behind the increase in representation and find evidence consistent with electoral demand for Romanian-born candidates, rather than candidate supply, driving the result. First, we examine the supply of foreign-born (elected and non-elected) candidates using original hand-collected data from a subset of municipalities. While the number of foreign-born candidates increased across several immigrant groups after 2007, only Romanian-born candidates experienced greater electoral success. Second, we find evidence of increased turnout among Romanian voters. Third, municipalities facing more competitive elections were more likely to elect Romanian-born councilors. Finally, no immigrant community other than Romanians benefited electorally from the enfranchisement of Romanians. Taken together, these findings suggest that established political parties in electorally competitive municipalities with large Romanian pop-

[3] This approach is inspired by Mastrobuoni and Pinotti (2015) and Bernini et al. (2025), adapted to our context. Compared to Mastrobuoni and Pinotti (2015), our unit of observation is the municipality rather than the individual, and treatment intensity increases with the share of the relevant group within each municipality. Intuitively, no municipality is composed exclusively of Romanians or Albanians. Furthermore, immigrants from other EU candidate countries are too few to be politically relevant at the municipal level and therefore do not constitute a suitable control group for Romanians. Compared to Bernini et al. (2025), we leverage smaller geographical units as well as a much less salient treatment from the perspective of the already enfranchised population (making backlash extremely unlikely). Differently from Bernini et al. (2025), our context does not allow for pure-control municipalities, however we can rely on placebo immigrant communities who did not gain EU citizenship.

ulations strategically included Romanian-born candidates on their lists to attract votes from newly enfranchised immigrants, anticipating co-ethnic voting patterns within the newly enfranchised Romanian community.

Our second set of findings shows that the effects of expanded rights extend beyond political participation to prosocial behavior. Building on previous findings that naturalization increases social capital (e.g. participation in civic networks) and human capital via security of residence and a stronger sense of belonging (Hainmueller et al. 2017; Gathmann and Keller 2017), we ask whether a milder form of rights expansion through EU citizenship generates similar effects. Using data on organ donation consent by birthplace, we find a sharp increase in new consents among Romanians following 2007, after controlling for municipal Romanian population.[4] This finding not only shows an effect on prosocial behavior but is also important in its own right, given the long waiting times for organ transplants in Italy, where many patients remain on waiting lists for years. Importantly, no comparable effect emerges among Albanians, Moroccans, or other non-EU Orthodox groups, suggesting that the increase was driven by EU citizenship rather than broader cultural or social trends. During the first five years after 2007, the number of new consents per municipality rises steadily from a low starting point and then stabilizes after 2012 at a level two to four times higher than in the pre-entry period.[5] The IV analysis rules out compositional changes as a possible mechanism for the results and it shows that the effect is concentrated among pre-existing Romanian residents, consistent with expanded rights increasing long-term attachment to the host country.[6] The stark increase in consents to donation between 2007 and 2012, when people had to actively opt in to express consent, further rules out mechanical effects due to changes in the way consent is expressed. Instead, our results are consistent with a direct effect of EU citizenship: by increasing residence security and voting rights, EU citizenship may have raised expectations of long-term settlement, thereby strengthening immigrants' sense of belonging and increasing their commitment to the host community (or the incentives to build social reputation).

In our third set of findings, we explore whether the extension of EU citizenship to a large group of immigrants mitigates natives' backlash. In principle, this could happen both directly, via the vote of the newly enfranchised immigrants, or indirectly via improving natives' perception of new EU citizens. We test this effect on two sets of outcomes: the ideological orientation of the municipal government and municipal public spending. With respect to ideology, we find an overall increase in electoral support for right-wing parties in municipalities with higher immigrant populations.[7] As for

[4] We observe new consents, expressed yearly via the NGO AIDO, which was the main channel to express consent until 2012, when consent for donation started to be asked in the Italian ID card application process.

[5] Out of roughly 100.000 new consents we observe between 2003 and 2007, only 100 were Romanian-born, that is 0.1%, despite Romanians being almost 1% of the Italian population. However, of roughly 100.000 new consents that we observe between 2015 and 2018, more than 500 were Romanian-born, that is 0.5%, with Romanians being 2% of the Italian population in that period.

[6] If anything, when donation consent is measured as a share of the municipal Romanian population, newly arrived Romanians appear to reduce it. This suggests that recent arrivals do not provide consent immediately, while mechanically increasing the denominator.

[7] In particular, right-leaning parties in Italy have either advocated for anti-immigrant policies themselves or have been in coalitions with parties that did so, during our observation period. However, we find an overall increase in

spending patterns, we find an increase in public security spending and a decrease in social spending, as shares of total expenditure, in municipalities with a higher immigrant presence. Crucially, this pattern is identical in municipalities with large Romanian immigrant populations and in those with large Albanian or Moroccan populations. Because the effect on the winning party is the same whether or not the relevant immigrant group has EU citizenship, we conclude that immigration shifts the political orientation of the winning party to the right, while voting (and residency) rights per se have no significant effect. This finding aligns with Barone et al. (2016), who show increased support for center-right parties in national and local elections in response to immigration, and is consistent with newspaper articles reporting, if anything, a worsening perception of Romanians among Italians after EU accession (Hooper 2007; González 2007).

Our paper contributes to three different strands of literature. First, it contributes to the literature on immigrant rights and integration. Importantly, our setting isolates an extension of rights, namely residency and local voting rights, without naturalization or full labor market liberalization. Related work has examined the impact of expanding immigrants' rights on their political integration (Engdahl et al. 2020; Bratsberg et al. 2021; Shertzer 2016), on redistribution through public finance (Razin and Sadka 2017; Ferwerda 2021) and on the behavior of elected officials (Bhatiya 2025). Legalization of previously undocumented immigrants was also shown to improve their labor market outcomes (Kossoudji and Cobb-Clark 2002; Lozano and Sorensen 2011; Pan 2012; Steigleder and Sparber 2017), reduce crime (Mastrobuoni and Pinotti 2015; Pinotti 2017), increase tax compliance (Cascio and Lewis 2019) and raise state transfers to immigrant-populated regions (Sabet and Winter 2024). However, to our knowledge, no study has explored the combined impact of expanded voting and residency rights (in the absence of naturalization) on immigrants' political integration and prosocial behavior. These reforms are particularly important because they tend to be less salient to natives than naturalization and may therefore be more politically feasible.

We contribute to this literature in four ways. First, we show that EU citizenship has immediate effects on political representation: municipalities with more Romanian citizens are significantly more likely to elect Romanian-born councilors. This is particularly relevant in light of the historical under-representation of immigrants in politics (Dancygier et al. 2021). Second, we find that expanding immigrants' voting and residency rights enhances consent to organ donation, which we see as a proxy for prosocial behavior. Third, we identify the mechanism behind the increase in representation, showing that it is not the newly arrived immigrants driving the results and that candidate supply alone is insufficient. Instead, it is the combination of increased electoral participation of long-term resident immigrants, and the resulting demand for co-ethnic candidates, that drives greater political representation. Fourth, our findings provide insights into how additional EU enlargements (e.g. to the Balkans or Ukraine), which necessarily extend EU citizenship rights, would affect the socio-political integration of immigrants from newly acceding member states.

Second, our paper relates to the long-standing literature on enfranchisement conditional on citizenship status, which has largely focused on women's suffrage and the U.S. Voting Rights Act.

support for right-wing parties in municipalities with higher immigrant populations.

This literature distinguishes between direct effects of enfranchisement, such as increases in political participation and representation, and indirect effects operating through politicians' responses or reactions by other groups. Existing studies document direct effects on political participation and policies directly chosen by voters (Cascio and Washington 2014; Funk and Gathmann 2015; Cascio and Shenhav 2020). They also provide evidence of indirect effects, as politicians respond to newly enfranchised voters by expanding government size and increasing social and education spending (Lott and Kenny 1999; Abrams and Settle 1999; Washington 2008; Aidt and Dallal 2008; Kose et al. 2020), as well as state transfers (Cascio and Washington 2014). Similarly, the U.S. Voting Rights Act has been shown to affect policing (Facchini et al. 2025) and to trigger backlash among white constituents (Bernini et al. 2025). We contribute to this literature by instead focusing on immigrants and by providing evidence on both direct and indirect effects in a setting where voting and residency rights expand without naturalization. We document clear direct effects in terms of representation, political participation (despite the limited electoral weight of Romanians), and prosocial behavior, but no indirect effects on targeted spending or ideological backlash.

Finally, we contribute to the local elections literature by hand-collecting the largest existing dataset of non-elected candidates in Italian municipal elections, an extensively studied institutional setting (Baltrunaite et al. (2014), Bordignon et al. (2016), Baltrunaite et al. (2019), Perez-Vincent (2023)).

2 Institutional Context

Italy is a particularly suitable setting for studying the effects of expanding immigrant rights and integration, for several reasons. First, it has a substantial foreign-born population, which constituted 10.4 percent of the total population in 2019 (OECD 2022), and is also the primary destination country for Romanian immigrants, the population of interest in this study. Second, as a member state of the EU, foreign EU nationals can participate in local elections and legally reside in Italy without a visa. Third, Italy has around 8,000 municipal governments where EU citizens can vote and run for office, offering fine-grained data and substantial variation. Finally, since these municipal offices are virtually pro bono, they mainly reflect political and civic engagement rather than financial or career incentives.

Since 1990, Italy has consistently experienced net in-migration flows, with immigrants arriving mainly from Romania, Albania and Morocco.[8] Italy is the main destination for Romanian immigrants, hosting 300,000 in 2005 and almost 1.2 million in 2017, with a large increase following EU accession (Figure A.1). As shown in Figure 1, immigrants of all origins tend to concentrate in the northern and central parts of the country, where the majority of manufacturing jobs are located. Municipalities with more immigration tend to be larger on average, and although areas with a larger share of Romanians also have a higher presence of other immigrant communities (see

[8]Source: Istituto Cattaneo

Table A.1), there is substantial variation across municipalities in the share of Romanians among all foreign residents, as illustrated in Figure A.2.

2.1 EU Accession and Expansion of Romanian Rights in Italy

EU enlargements have progressively expanded the set of nationalities covered by EU citizenship; as new countries joined, additional immigrant groups experienced improvements in their rights. Following the conclusion of negotiations in 2004 and the European Commission's approval in 2006, Romania and Bulgaria joined the EU in 2007. This wave of enlargement was particularly relevant for Italy, where Romanians account for around 20% of the immigrant population.[9]

Romania's entry into the EU affected Romanians in Italy along several dimensions discussed below. However, especially between 2007 and 2012, when other channels remained closed or unchanged, the most significant effects were the extension of voting and residency rights.

Residency and Legal Status The most consequential change brought by EU citizenship for Romanians in Italy was the right to reside in the country without a visa or residence permit (*permesso di soggiorno*).

Prior to Romania's accession to the EU, the primary channel through which Romanians could reside in Italy was the work visa system. Each year, Italy set a quota for non-EU workers (e.g., 170,000 in 2006). Subject to this cap, an Italian employer had to sponsor and request a specific worker from abroad.[10] Upon approval, the worker was granted a visa tied to that employer and subsequently received a residence permit. The duration of the permit depended on the type of contract (seasonal, fixed-term, open-ended), ranging from six months to two years. Even workers with permanent contracts were generally required to renew their permits every two years. In the event of job loss, workers could receive unemployment benefits, but they typically had to secure new employment within six months in order to maintain their residence permit. The second most important channel was family reunification, which allowed spouses, children, and dependent parents to join the worker, provided that the latter held a valid residence permit, met minimum income requirements, and could provide adequate housing. This system remains largely in place today for non-EU immigrants, with some relaxations regarding the duration of stay following job loss and broader access to employment for holders of family-based residence permits.[11]

A relevant effect of the removal of visa requirements for Romanians was the regularization of previously irregular immigrants. Although no official data are available, estimates suggest that between 2004 and 2007 irregular non-EU immigrants accounted for 10–20% of the total non-EU immigrant population in Italy (Fondazione ISMU (2007)). Notably, the largest legalization program

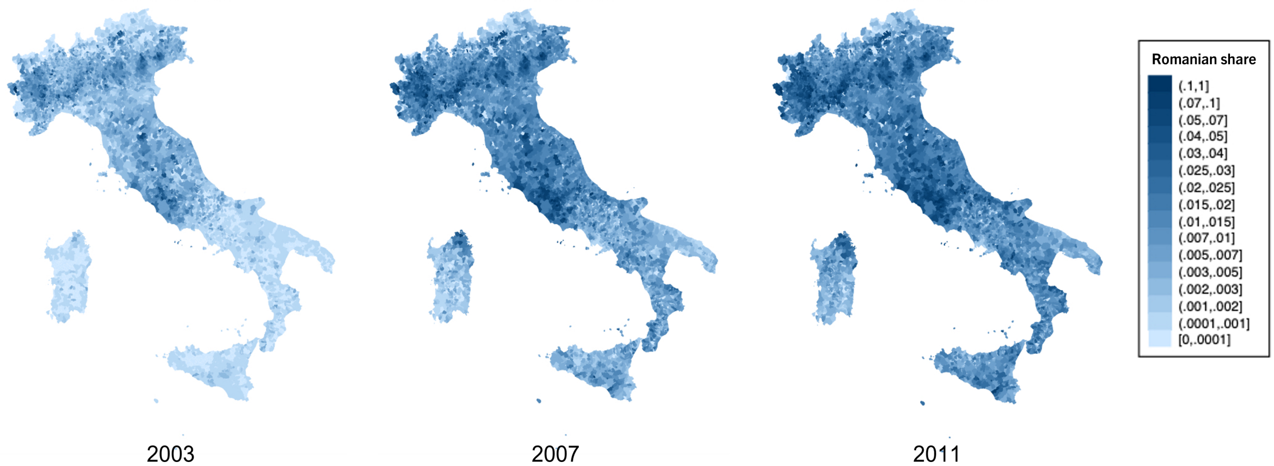
[9] Although Bulgaria joined the EU at the same time as Romania, we focus primarily on Romanians, as Bulgarians constitute only a small fraction of the immigrant population in Italy, less than one-twentieth the size of the Romanian population. Robustness checks that include Bulgarians do not alter our results and, if anything, strengthen them.

[10] Depending on bilateral agreements, some countries (but not Romania) had a reserved number of slots.

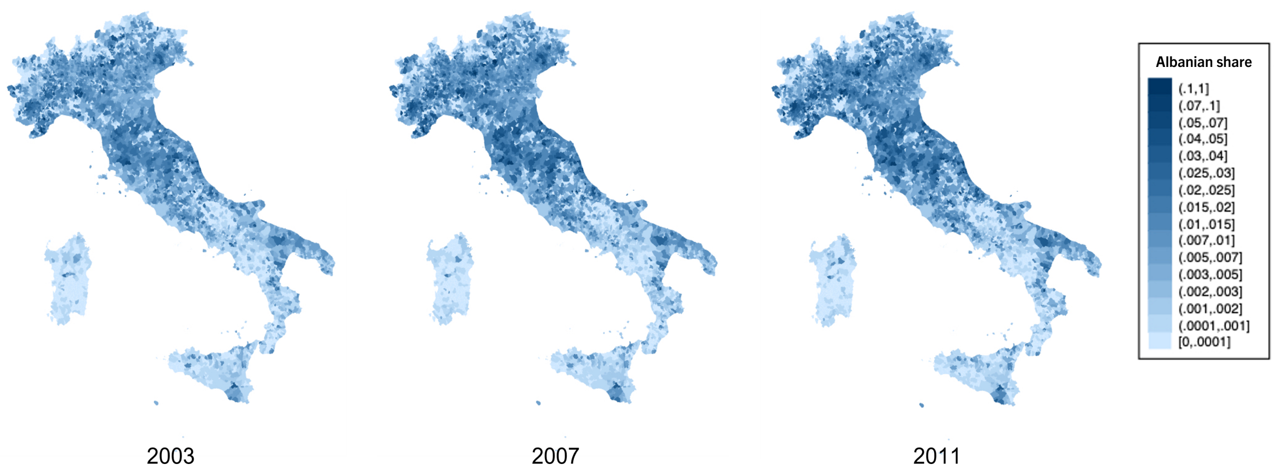
[11] Other permits, such as student visas, allowed a small number of Romanians to reside in Italy for specific purposes.

Figure 1: Evolution of Immigration Shares in Italian Municipalities by Country of Origin

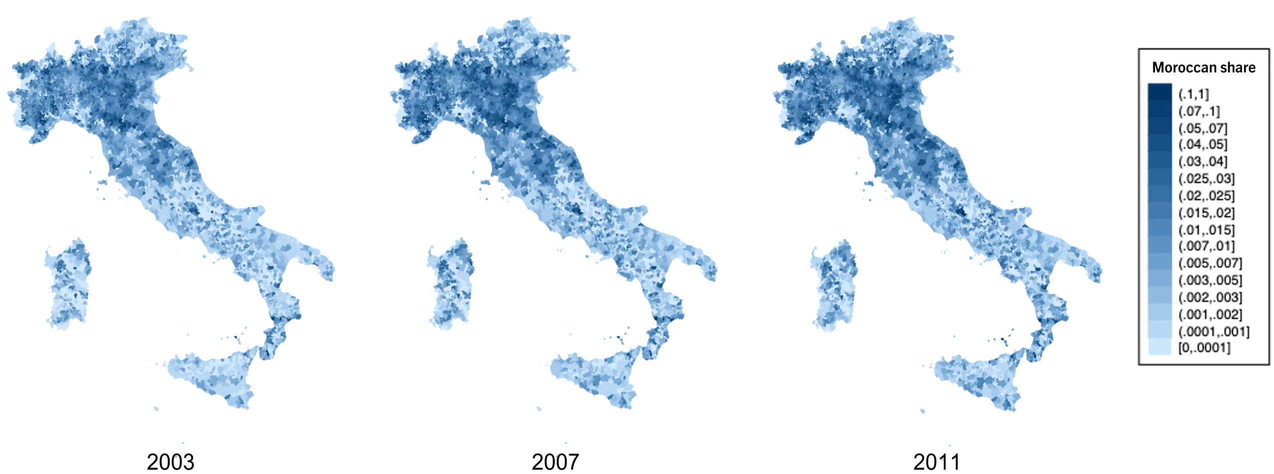
Romanian Share by Municipality and Year



Albanian Share by Municipality and Year



Moroccan Share by Municipality and Year



in Italian history took place in 2002, resulting in the regularization of nearly 650,000 immigrants in 2003, most of whom were Romanians, Albanians, or Moroccans. Importantly, none of our outcomes exhibit a significant discontinuity around 2002, which suggests that regularization alone is unlikely to account for the effects we observe on representation and prosocial behavior.

Voting Rights As a consequence of Romania's accession to the EU in 2007, Romanian citizens in Italy gained the right to vote in municipal elections and to run for municipal council seats, but not for the offices of mayor or vice-mayor. This opened opportunities for civic and political participation while largely excluding them from positions that carry substantial financial rewards or career advantages. EU Council Directive 94/80/EC (1994) requires that every member state extend the right to vote in municipal elections—and to run as candidates—to EU citizens residing in a member state of which they are not nationals. Italy adopted the directive in 1996 and enacted a law granting non-Italian EU citizens who reside in Italy access to municipal electoral contests.[12] The law gave non-Italian EU citizens full voting rights in municipal elections, with the sole condition that they register on a special list of non-Italian residents eligible to vote in the municipality. Registration is required only for non-Italians voting in the municipality for the first time. The law also regulates the right of non-Italian EU citizens to run as candidates, provided that they submit documentation from their home country confirming their eligibility for election.

Italian Citizenship By gaining EU citizenship, Romanians became eligible to acquire Italian citizenship via a fast-track process. However, this provision cannot explain the results we observe between 2007 and 2014, because no Romanian could have benefited from it during that period. Non-EU citizens must reside in Italy for ten years before applying for Italian citizenship and then wait several additional years (in any case, no less than two) for their application to be processed. EU citizens, by contrast, need only four years of residence before applying, followed by the same, lengthy, document-processing period. Although Romania's accession to the EU granted Romanians access to this expedited route, years of residence accumulated before 2007 could not be counted toward the four-year requirement. Consequently, a Romanian who moved to Italy in 2003 would still have needed to complete four additional years of residence after 2007 before becoming eligible to apply, and then wait several other years (in any case, no less than two) to obtain citizenship. As a result, naturalization through this route could not have occurred before 2013 at the earliest, and more plausibly not before 2014.

Public Services EU citizenship on its own changed relatively little in Romanians' access to public services. Healthcare in Italy is universal, so both non-EU and EU citizens residing in Italy have the same access to public healthcare. The same is true of the education system. As for other welfare benefits, such as public housing or child benefits, eligibility is often conditioned on years of

[12] Law 1996, n.197

legal residence, while explicit discrimination based solely on citizenship is typically unlawful and subject to legal challenge.

Labor Market Access By eliminating the need for visas or residence permits, EU citizenship granted Romanians easier access to the Italian labor market; however access to the labor market was not immediate for Romanians. Instead, it was introduced gradually, as existing EU member states were permitted to impose temporary restrictions on labor market access during a transition period. Until 2012, Italy imposed a quota system and required Romanians to obtain a work permit, limiting the number of new Romanian workers per sector. Exceptions were made for certain sectors—–including agriculture, hospitality, construction, and domestic work—–as well as for highly qualified professionals, who were not required to obtain a work permit. EU citizenship also allowed Romanians to take public sector jobs unavailable to non-EU citizens, such as positions in the police force and the military. However, survey data show that the share of Romanians in these occupations remained negligible (see Table A.2).

We do not observe how Romanian employment changed after 2007. However, a survey by the Vienna Institute for International Economic Studies (WIIW) on Romanian immigrants in Italy allows us to glean information about how the demographic and economic characteristics compare between those who arrived before and after accession.[13] The survey interviewed a thousand individuals in 2011. We use national weights provided by the survey to obtain nationally representative statistics. Table A.3 shows that Romanians who arrived during 2007–2010 are significantly, and by construction, younger (and thus unmarried, without dependent children) compared to those who arrived in 2004–2006. They are also less educated and way less likely to be registered to vote. Table A.2 shows the sectoral distribution of employment for Romanians arriving before and after 2007. Across all sectors, the only significant changes are a 6.1 percentage point increase in the share of Romanians looking for work, reflecting the fact that migration was no longer tied to employment-based visas, and a 5 and 2.9 percentage point decrease in the shares working in manufacturing and hospitality, respectively. The large but statistically insignificant 4.1 percentage point increase in the share working in construction may reflect the exemption of construction from the quota system.

2.2 Municipal Governments in Italy

Non-Italian EU citizens residing in Italy can vote in municipal elections. Municipalities constitute the lowest level of government in Italy. While the size of a municipality ranges from a few hundred inhabitants to approximately 2.5 million (Rome), the median municipality has 2,293 residents. Figure A.3 shows the distribution of population across municipalities. Even at the ninetieth percentile,

[13]The survey interviewed approximately 1,000 Romanian immigrants in 2011. The target population consisted of Romanian nationals legally residing in Italy since May 1, 2004, aged 16 or older, and living in Rome, Turin, Milan, or their surrounding areas. The sample was allocated across cities using official population statistics from the Italian National Statistical Institute (ISTAT) and the Centers Sampling Method (Baio et al. 2011) commonly used in migration surveys. Survey weights were provided to improve representativeness and correct for differential sampling probabilities, and we apply the national weights in all analyses.

a municipality has only 12,212 residents, highlighting the granularity of the data.

Each municipality functions as a local government and is managed by a mayor and a municipal council. The size of the council increases discontinuously with municipal population, ranging from a minimum and a median of 12 councilors and a maximum of 60. After 2011, these bounds were reduced to 10 and 48, respectively. The mayor is directly elected by the municipal population. The candidate whose party or supporting coalition receives the most votes becomes mayor. Two-thirds of the council seats are then allocated to that party or coalition, while the remaining seats are proportionally distributed among the opposition parties.[14] Voters can also express a preference for a candidate-councilor and, within each party, the candidates receiving the most votes are elected.[15] Municipal elections in Italy have high turnout rates, generally comparable to those for the general election and consistently exceeding 60 percent from 2000 to 2020, as depicted in Figure A.4.

Municipal councilors typically meet once a month to deliberate and vote on local issues. Earning less than 300 euros per year, they have little financial or career incentive. The latter is especially true for foreign nationals, who cannot hold higher political office. As a result, the main motivation for running is often a desire to engage with and shape local civic life.

2.3 Consent to Organ Donation

In 2024, around 4,600 organs were transplanted in Italy, while nearly 8,600 people remained on the waiting list. Despite strong performance within Europe, the average waiting time for a kidney transplant was 20.2 months, which required priority rules to allocate scarce organs (Bac 2026). Registered consent to organ donation is crucial to speeding up the process in a time-sensitive setting, as physicians can rely directly on the deceased individual's recorded decision without contacting family members. Moreover, it substantially increases the likelihood of transplantation, as even a single objection among equally ranked family members can, in the absence of registered consent, prevent the procedure (De Min et al. 2025).

In Italy, consent can be expressed through different channels. Until 2012, prospective donors had to opt in, primarily through membership in AIDO (the Italian association of organ donors, which often organizes awareness campaigns and registrations in public squares) or through declarations filed with local health authorities. Declarations made through both channels were centrally recorded in the national transplant information system.[16] While there is no accessible figure for total consents in Italy before 2012, AIDO is considered the main channel to express consent, with more than 1.2 million declarations recorded between 1975 and 2012 in our data. Following a legislative change in 2012 (implemented in 2013), individuals are also asked directly for their consent when applying

[14] Municipalities with more than 15,000 inhabitants hold runoff elections among the top two candidates, if the winner does not obtain the absolute majority.

[15] At the polling station, voters can find some information about the candidate-councilor, including the place of birth. See Figure A.6 in the Appendix for example.

[16] While consent could also be expressed privately through signed donor cards or written declarations, these were not centrally recorded.

for an Italian identity card, which is required for all Italian citizens aged 18 and over. According to the Italian Ministry of Health, approximately 5 million people in Italy had consented to organ donation by 2019, 1.4 million of whom via AIDO; total consents reached 15 million in 2024.[17]

Since 2013, the Italian ID card application process contains a question on consent. This does not pose a concern for our identification strategy in the 2007–2012 period. However, if more Romanians requested an Italian ID card following EU accession, this could mechanically increase observed consent rates starting from 2013. This is unlikely for two reasons. First, non-Italians residing in Italy can continue to use identity documents issued by their home country. EU citizens can use their national ID cards, while non-EU citizens can use their passport and residence permit. Although both groups can apply for an Italian ID card, many do not, since alternative documents are generally sufficient. Second, following Romania's accession to the EU in 2007 (and in force well before 2013), Romanian citizens in particular could rely on their Romanian national ID cards for intra-EU identification, further reducing any incentive to obtain an Italian ID card. In practice, this means that even after 2012, foreign nationals, and especially EU citizens, are less frequently asked about consent through document-based interactions than Italians. Instead, they typically opt in through AIDO. Importantly, consent rates among non-Italians remain very low. For instance, of the 100,000 individuals who expressed consent via AIDO between 2015 and 2018, the overwhelming majority were Italian-born, while only about 500 were Romanian-born (0.5%), despite Romanians accounting for approximately 2% of the Italian population in that period.

3 Data

The dataset for our analysis combines multiple sources, including original archival data. The main dataset, from the Italian National Institute of Statistics (ISTAT), provides information on the number of foreign residents and their citizenship status for approximately 8,000 municipalities, covering a sample period of 2003–2018.[18][19] The level of analysis is municipality-by-year (or municipality-by-election year). The summary statistics for our variables are provided in Table A.4.

Administrative Electoral Data We merge our main dataset with electoral data to study political outcomes, including representation and the ideological orientation of the winning party. Using the *Anagrafe degli amministratori locali* provided by the Italian Ministry of Interior, we collect information on all municipal officials in office as of December 31, each year from 1986 to 2020. The dataset records office held (e.g., councilor, mayor), municipality of birth, education level, and political party. For representatives born outside Italy, their country of birth is listed instead of a municipality. However, we do not observe their citizenship status. The map in Figure A.5 shows municipalities with Romanian-born councilors before and after 2007.

[17] Ministry statement in 2019 and 2024 national data.

[18] Individuals with both an Italian and a foreign citizenship are not in the these data, which only include foreigners.

[19] Because of municipality splits and mergers, the number of municipalities may differ from year to year.

We augment our dataset by adding information on all municipal and regional electoral returns between 2000 and 2020, as provided by the Italian Ministry of the Interior. For municipal elections, we collect data on the election date, registered voters and turnout, as well as the votes received by each party. For regional elections, we collect data on the number of registered voters and votes cast; these are measured at the municipality level to allow for a comparison with the corresponding outcomes in simultaneous municipal elections.

Original Electoral Data We conducted a large-scale collection of original electoral records. Since Italy only records *elected* officials, data on all *candidates* do not exist. To address this, we contacted all Italian municipalities by email, requesting that they send us their complete electoral rosters starting from 2002. Figure A.6 is an example of an electoral roster we digitized. Among the municipalities that responded, we digitized those with at least one pre-2008 electoral roster available. In total, we obtained data for 333 municipalities for which we have the birthplaces of the candidates.[20] For additional 343 municipalities, we collected the names of all candidates, but not their birthplaces, and in these cases we assigned nationality based on the origin of the name.[21]

Organ Donation Consent Registry We use data from the Italian Organ Donors Association (AIDO) for 2003—2018, which include the number, municipality of residence, and place of birth of individuals who consented to posthumous organ donation in each year. This means that we observe the flow of new donors, rather than the stock. While citizenship is not recorded, we use their place of birth as a proxy. Between 1975 and 2019 we observe more than 1.4 million consents via AIDO.

Local Public Finance We take local public finance data from the Italian Public Authority Data (AIDA PA). We observe annual municipal revenues by source (e.g., tax type or transfers from the state) and municipal spending by type of use. To facilitate comparison across municipalities, we construct revenue and expenditure shares for categories of interest by dividing the revenue or expenditure in each category by the municipality's total revenue or total expenditure, respectively.

Migration and Sectoral Employment For our supplementary IV analysis, we merge Italian sectoral employment data with migration data from OECD. First, we combine municipality-level sectoral employment data with nationwide foreign employment data by sector from ISTAT to

[20]Figure A.7 shows these municipalities on a map of Italy, while Table A.5 describes how they differ from all Italian municipalities. These municipalities are a selected subsample: the average population tends to be higher (but the median is still small, with 3416 inhabitants compared to 2422 of the full sample), more likely from the north, with more Romanian citizens (1.5% vs 1.3%) and more Romanians elected (0.2% vs 0.9%).

[21] In practice, we use the sample of 333 'certain' municipalities, where we can confidently assign each candidate their correct birthplace, as our primary sample. As a robustness exercise in Figure A.8, we include the remaining 343 municipalities: for those, we follow Marschke et al. (2018) and rely on Ethnea (Torvik and Agarwal 2016), assigning each politician a nationality based on their first and last names. To reduce false positives, we classify a candidate as Romanian only when the joint probability that both the name and surname are Romanian exceeds 85%. The limitation of Ethnea is that while it can reliably identify Romanian-origin candidates, it cannot distinguish the Albanian or Moroccan ones (typically classifying them as Slav and Arabic, respectively).

estimate the share of foreign employment in each municipality. Both datasets are from the 2001 census, the last census before Romania's accession to the EU. The sectoral data cover seventeen sectors. Next, we examine annual Romanian emigration to destinations other than Italy. The OECD migration database provides yearly outflows of Romanians to OECD destinations. However, data collection is not consistent for all destinations. The outflow variable is available for the entire observation period of our IV analysis (2003–2018) for 19 OECD countries.[22]

4 Empirical Strategy

4.1 Effects of Extending EU Citizenship to Romanians

Following Romania's accession to the EU in January 2007, Romanian nationals residing in Italy gained the right to vote and run in Italian municipal elections, as well as the right to stay in the country without a residence permit or a visa. We conduct an event study around 2007 to examine the effects of this expansion of rights on political representation, prosocial behavior, the political orientation of the winning party, and local public finance. Our main specification is as follows:

$$Y_{mt} = \alpha + \big[\sum_{s=1986}^{2020} \gamma_s ImSh_m^{2003} \times \mathbb{1}_t\{t=s\}\big] + \eta_m + \theta_t + \varepsilon_{mt}. \tag{1}$$

In this equation, Y_{mt} is the outcome variable for municipality m in year (or election year) t and $ImSh_m^{2003}$ is the share of immigrants from a given origin country in municipality m in 2003, the first year for which we have immigrant counts based on their origin country at the municipality level. We fix the share of immigrants at its 2003 level as our time-invariant measure. Finally, η_m and θ_t represent municipality and year fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the municipality level to account for the correlations in the error term among observations in the same municipality.

Because Romanian citizens became eligible to vote and run in local elections only after accession, this institutional change ensures that Romanian immigrants in Italy were only treated after 2007. We argue that the 2003 share of Romanian immigrants is exogenous to the event because the official conclusion of accession negotiations with Romania was confirmed by the European Council only on December 17, 2004. In other words, Romanian residents living in Italian municipalities in 2003 could not have anticipated with certainty that they would benefit from the subsequent expansion of rights. In particular, this means that the 2003 share of Romanians is unlikely to suffer from reverse causality.

In our main specification, we estimate equation (1) for Romanians. However, for comparison, we also estimate the specification for Albanians and Moroccans, the largest immigrant groups after Romanians during the observation period. This placebo analysis aims to assess whether the

[22] These 19 destination countries are Australia, Austria, the Czech Republic, Denmark, Finland, Germany, Hungary, Iceland, South Korea, Luxembourg, the Netherlands, New Zealand, Norway, the Slovak Republic, Slovenia, Spain, Sweden, Switzerland, and Turkey.

observed changes reflect broader trends related to immigrants in general or are specifically driven by the expansion of rights to Romanian nationals. As Albanian and Moroccan immigrants did not acquire additional rights in Italy, we use them as our comparison group to separate out the general trend affecting immigrants.

Immigrants from other EU states could also, in theory, serve as a comparison group because they have had voting rights since 1996. However, two factors limit their usefulness for our study. First, in our analyses, we proxy the nationality of politicians (and of individuals consenting to organ donation) using place of birth, due to data limitations. Most residents born in higher-income Western European countries, such as Germany or France, have Italian names, suggesting that many are likely Italians born abroad or children of Italian emigrants rather than foreign nationals who immigrated to Italy. This complicates the analysis of the relevant population, since these foreign-born Italians have always had voting rights through their Italian citizenship. Second, German and French citizens are a useful control group because Germany and France were EU members throughout the sample period and, among countries that remained in the EU for the entire period, they constitute the largest immigrant groups in Italy. However, their populations are still substantially smaller than the Romanian population. By contrast, Albanian and Moroccan populations are more comparable in size to the Romanian population, making them a more suitable comparison group.

Similarly, we focus on Romania rather than other Eastern European countries that joined the EU in the 2004 enlargement for two main reasons. First, we only observe the number of immigrants by nationality in Italian municipalities starting in 2003, which prevents us from establishing a meaningful pre-treatment period for countries admitted in 2004. Second, migration from these countries to Italy is more than an order of magnitude smaller than that from Romania. For instance, although Poland is the largest country of origin among the 2004 entrants, there are roughly ten times more Romanians than Poles living in Italy.

4.2 Who drives the effect? Long-term Residents vs. New Arrivals

Although the 2003 share of Romanians is predetermined with respect to the 2007 acquisition of EU citizenship, we also want to rule out the possibility that results may be driven by selective sorting of post-2007 Romanian arrivals across municipalities. In particular, municipalities may differ in unobserved characteristics that both attract immigrants and increase the likelihood of electing an immigrant-born councilor. For example, some municipalities may have become increasingly welcoming toward Romanians, following 2007. If so, the free mobility introduced by EU accession – which generated substantial post-2007 inflows – may have led Romanian immigrants to disproportionately settle in these municipalities.

Distinguishing whether the observed increase in political representation is driven by the pre-2007 stock of Romanian residents or by (potentially endogenous) post-2007 inflows is also important from a conceptual standpoint. Indeed, the two channels carry very different policy implications. In the former case, increased representation would reflect a previously settled population that, despite lacking voting rights and secure residency status, was already partially integrated into the local labor and housing markets due to pre-existing visa requirements. In the latter case, it would reflect newly arrived immigrants facing substantially greater socio-economic barriers.[23]

To directly address both points above, we implement the following shift–share IV strategy:

$$Y_{mt} = \beta_0 + \beta^E Early_{mt} + \gamma^E Early_{mt} \times Post2007_t + \gamma^N \widehat{New_{mt}} + \eta_m + \theta_t + \nu_{mt} \tag{2}$$

Here, $Early_{mt}$ denotes the share of pre-existing Romanians, and New_{mt} the share of Romanians who arrived in municipality m in year t, after the accession. $Early_{mt}$ evolves over time until 2007, after which it is fixed at the 2007 level. In an alternative specification, we use the share of Romanian immigrants in municipality m in 2003 as a pre-determined proxy for $Early_{mt}$.

New_{mt} presents the endogeneity problem described above. To address this, we construct an instrument for the share of new Romanian immigrants that captures inflows into a given municipality but is otherwise uncorrelated with the outcome variables. More precisely, we instrument for New_{mt}, with the following expression:

$$Z_{mt} = \big(\sum_{sector} EmpShare^{2001}_{m,sector} \times ForeignEmp^{2001}_{sector} \big) \times Outflow_t. \tag{3}$$

In this equation, $EmpShare^{2001}_{m,sector}$ is the employment share of a given *sector* in municipality m in 2001 and $ForeignEmp^{2001}_{sector}$ is the number of foreign workers employed in the *sector* in year 2000 as a fraction of total workers in the *sector* nationwide. Our data provide the municipal-level employment share for 17 sectors in 2001. The total outflow of Romanian immigrants to destinations other than Italy from 2007 to year t is denoted by $Outflow_t$. The idea is to first weight the sectoral employment share in each municipality by how likely each sector's job openings are to be filled by foreign workers at baseline. Then, this figure is multiplied by the yearly outflow of Romanians to estimate the amount of foreign employment that is likely to be taken up by Romanians.

The key idea is that each municipality faces labor demand in specific sectors that is more likely to be met by foreign workers than by natives. Under the assumption that workers from different origin countries are substitutes, the share of these positions filled by Romanians is proportional to Romanian emigration flows to destinations other than Italy – an exogenous source of variation in Romanian migrant supply. We restrict the analysis to sectors in which Romanians could work without a permit during the adjustment period (2007–2011), thereby excluding sectors such as manufacturing and wholesale and retail trade that employ many foreign employees but were inaccessible to new arrivals after accession. In fact, Romanians who arrived after the accession were far more likely to be employed in sectors exempted from work permit requirements for Romanians.[24][25]

[23] The former mechanism is informative for policies expanding voting and residency rights for immigrants already residing in the host country, whereas the latter is more relevant in contexts where large immigrant inflows are expected.

[24] See Section 2.

[25] Included sectors are Agriculture, Hunting, and Forestry; Fishing, Pisciculture, and Related Services; Construc-

Identification Assumptions Our identification strategy relies on two main assumptions. First, sectoral employment in 2001 is predetermined. Indeed, sectoral employment in 2001 cannot be affected by the Romanian inflow, which mainly occurred years after 2001. Second, the outflow of Romanians in a given year to destinations other than Italy is driven by factors external to Italian municipalities, such as international conditions or economic and political developments in Romania.

The main threat to identification is thus that the long-run sectoral composition of a municipal labor market, and specifically its historical propensity to hire foreigners, could influence the likelihood of electing a Romanian-born councilor after 2007 through channels other than the arrival of new Romanians. To address this concern, we include municipality and year fixed effects, which absorb time-invariant municipal characteristics and shocks common to all municipalities in a given year. We therefore argue that, conditional on these fixed effects, sectoral employment in 2001 affects the election of Romanian-born councilors after 2007 only through its effect on the share of Romanians (who leave Romania for reasons external to Italian municipalities) settling in a given municipality. Under this standard shift-share assumption, the exclusion restriction is not violated.

5 Findings

5.1 Effect of EU Citizenship on Romanian Political Representation

5.1.1 Increase in Romanian-Born Councilors

Figure 2 presents the estimates from equation (1). The likelihood of having a municipal councilor born in Romania increased after Romania joined the EU in 2007. The outcome variable is a binary indicator for whether a municipality has a Romanian-born councilor, rather than a count, because municipalities rarely have more than one.[26] The independent variable of interest interacts year dummies with the municipal share of Romanian citizens in 2003.[27] The figure shows a flat and statistically insignificant pre-trend before 2007. Prior to 2007, Romanian nationals without Italian citizenship became eligible to run for office only after acquiring it. Starting from 2009, the likelihood of having a Romanian-born councilor in municipalities with a larger time-invariant share of Romanians increases significantly.[28]

tion; Hotels and Restaurants; Financial Intermediaries; Real Estate, Informatics, Research, Other Professional and Entrepreneurial Activities; Public Administration and Defense; Education; Healthcare and Other Social Services; Domestic Services for Families; and International Organization. Those omitted are Mining and Quarrying; Manufacturing; Energy Utilities; Wholesale and Retail Trade, Repair of Motor Vehicles and Household Goods; Transportation and Distribution; and Other Public Social Services.

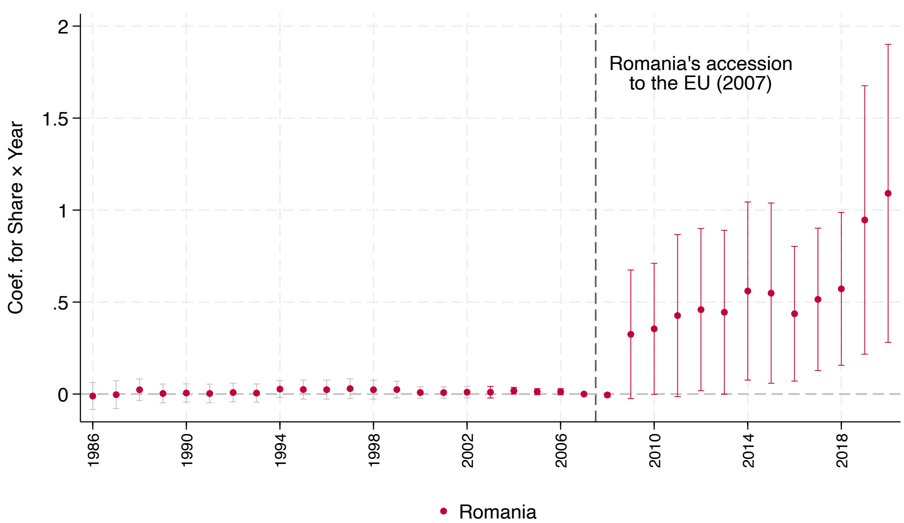
[26] In this figure, all municipalities appear in every year, not only in years when elections are held. The outcome is therefore a stock variable. Since elections do not occur annually, the outcome changes from year to year only for municipalities holding elections in that year, except in the rare cases where a councilor is replaced between elections. The other graphs in the main text do not have this feature.

[27] While 2003 is our baseline for the share of Romanian citizens, we do observe councilors' birthplace before 2003, between 1986–2002; we thus add this period and highlight it by using gray confidence intervals in the pre-2003 period.

[28] In Figure A.10, we include Bulgarians in the measures of immigrant share and councilor representation, reflecting the fact that Bulgaria also joined the EU in 2007. Specifically, we examine whether the likelihood of having a Romanian or Bulgarian councilor increases with the combined share of Romanian and Bulgarian immigrants in the

The lack of effects in 2008 is in part due to the asynchronous cycles of municipal elections, as shown in Figure A.9. Only a few elections occurred in 2008, while most municipalities held elections in 2009. Moreover, Romanian voters and candidates may not have fully benefited from accession in terms of political participation in 2008, as the bureaucratic steps necessary to vote and run in elections—such as obtaining the necessary documents from Romania and registering—were often delayed, especially in the first years after accession when administrative offices were overcrowded.[29] To address the former issue, in the rest of the paper we present electoral outcomes by grouping elections into electoral cycles, pooling together municipalities and elections within the same cycle.

Figure 2: Effect of EU Citizenship on Likelihood of Electing a Romanian-born Municipal Councilor



Notes: The graph above plots the coefficients of the interaction terms between Romanian share fixed at its 2003 level and year dummies, from Equation 1. The dependent variable is an indicator variable equal to 1 when the given municipality has a Romanian-born councilor in the given year and 0 otherwise. All 8,000 municipalities appear every year, regardless of whether an election is held in that year. Since 2003 is the first year in which we observe municipal foreign population by citizenship, we highlight the pre-2003 period by shading the corresponding confidence intervals in gray. The regression separately controls for municipality and year fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the municipality level. Bars represent 95% confidence intervals.

We conduct additional analyses at the electoral-cycle level, restricting observations to election years, to confirm our findings. First, we show that the results are robust to controlling for other large immigrant groups. To do so, we choose Albanians and Moroccans, the largest immigrant groups after Romanians, as our main comparison groups.[30] Specifically, we extend equation (1) to include, on the right-hand side, the shares of Albanians and Moroccans, fixed at their baseline levels, interacted with year dummies. We plot the result in Figure A.11a and confirm that the increase in the likelihood of having a Romanian-born councilor persists and is specific to places with more

municipality. The results remain unchanged.

[29]Newspaper articles report that registration procedures were suspended in 2007 due to overcrowding and the municipal authorities' lack of procedural know-how (Melting Pot Europa 2007). This issue likely persisted in 2008.

[30]We focus on these immigrant groups because, together with Romanians, they cover 40% of the immigrant population of Italy. These two groups are the only ones with a size comparable to Romanians in the period of interest. When the outcome variable is country-of-origin specific, we also present results with additional groups of immigrants.

Romanians. This suggests that it is not simply areas with more immigrants, but areas with more (enfranchised) Romanians that explain the increase in representation. Columns (1) and (2) of Table A.6 report the corresponding coefficients, with column (1) including municipality and year fixed effects and column (2) including municipality fixed effects and province-by-year fixed effects. The only significant coefficients confirm that it is places with more enfranchised Romanians, rather than with more Albanians or Moroccans, that are more likely to elect Romanian-born candidates.

We then perform placebo analyses in which we regress the presence of Albanian-born councilors on the 2003 share of Albanian citizens, and Moroccan-born councilors on the 2003 share of Moroccan citizens, both interacted with year dummies. To account for potential confounding from the presence of the other large immigrant groups, we control for the fixed shares of the remaining two immigrant groups interacted with the year dummies. The results are shown in Figure A.11b and Figure A.11c. Columns (3) to (6) of Table A.6 report the corresponding coefficients with year or province-by-year fixed effects. Around the time of Romania's accession, we do not observe an increase in the likelihood of having an Albanian-born councilor in places with more Albanians (Figure A.11b, or columns (3) and (4)) or a Moroccan-born councilor in places with more Moroccans (Figure A.11c, or columns (5) and (6)). These results rule out the possibility that a confounding event around 2007 increased the likelihood of electing foreign-born councilors more generally. We therefore conclude that Romania's accession is the only event around 2007 associated with an increase in Romanian-born councilor representation.

In the last electoral cycle, our placebo analyses for Albanians and Moroccans show statistically significant coefficients, although much smaller in magnitude than those for Romanians. A municipality with one more percentage point in the Romanian share in 2003 increases its likelihood of electing a Romanian-born councilor by 0.9 percentage points by the end of our period. In contrast, having one more percentage point in the Albanian or Moroccan share in 2003 increases the likelihood of an Albanian-born or Moroccan-born councilor by only 0.53 and 0.14 percentage points, respectively. We offer two explanations for this trend. First, voters in municipalities with larger immigrant populations may have become progressively more willing to elect foreign-born councilors due to persistent exposure. Second, and more importantly, Moroccan and especially Albanian immigrants acquired Italian citizenship at higher rates than Romanians, thereby gaining the right to vote and run for office (see the annual naturalization count by country of origin in Figure A.12). Naturalization represented a similar, but even stronger, expansion of rights than EU citizenship for a non-trivial share of the Albanian and Moroccan population.[31]

[31] While our municipal immigrant-share measure captures only non-Italians, it is based on shares observed in 2003. Because the fastest path to Italian citizenship for non-EU citizens requires at least 13 years of legal residence, many Albanians and Moroccans who were already present in 2003 would have had the opportunity to acquire Italian citizenship by 2018. This is reflected in substantially higher naturalization rates among Albanians and Moroccans than among Romanians. For instance, although Italy hosted about 450,000 Albanians and 1.2 million Romanians in 2015 (the year with the peak of naturalizations in our period), nearly 200,000 Albanians acquired Italian citizenship between 2015 and 2020, compared to only around 60,000 Romanians. This likely reflects both differences in migration timing and Italy's long residency requirements for citizenship. Albanians and Moroccans began immigrating to Italy in large numbers earlier than Romanians; for example, many Albanians arrived in the 1990s following the collapse of Albania's communist regime.

We next generalize the previous placebo analyses by considering additional immigrant groups. First, we ask whether municipalities with larger immigrant populations from origin country o are more likely to elect councilors born in o. Figure 3 reports the coefficients from this analysis for the following origin groups: Romania, Albania, Morocco, the next four major Muslim-majority countries (Bangladesh, Pakistan, Egypt, Tunisia), and the 18 largest remaining origin countries (dominated by China, India, the Philippines, Ukraine, and Moldova). Serving as a more comprehensive summary of the preceding analyses, this exercise qualitatively confirms our earlier findings, with Romanians emerging as the only group whose representation increased sharply immediately after 2007.

To further explore whether this pattern reflects substitution toward other immigrant groups, we examine whether enfranchised Romanians may have voted for councilors from other origins they perceived as more similar to themselves. To do so, we group councilors' birthplace and test whether municipalities with larger Romanian populations (i.e., fixing the 2003 Romanian share on the right-hand side) were more likely to elect councilors born in other relevant origin groups, namely Albania, Morocco, the next four major Muslim-majority countries, Eastern European countries within or outside the EU, and the rest of the world. The results are reported in Figure A.13. No group other than non-EU Eastern Europeans exhibits a noticeable positive coefficient. Although the estimates for non-EU Eastern Europeans are positive, they are not statistically significant.[32] Since the number of councilors born in all non-EU origin countries combined is almost four times larger than the number of Romanian-born councilors alone, these results are more consistent with relatively strong (Romanian) ethnic voting than with a lack of candidates from non-EU countries.

Magnitude A one–percentage-point increase in the Romanian population share in 2003 raises the probability that a municipality elects a Romanian-born councilor after 2007 by approximately 0.9 percentage points. Assessing the magnitude of this effect is not straightforward. At first glance, it appears small, given that the median municipality has ten councilors. However, the effect is non-trivial for at least two reasons.

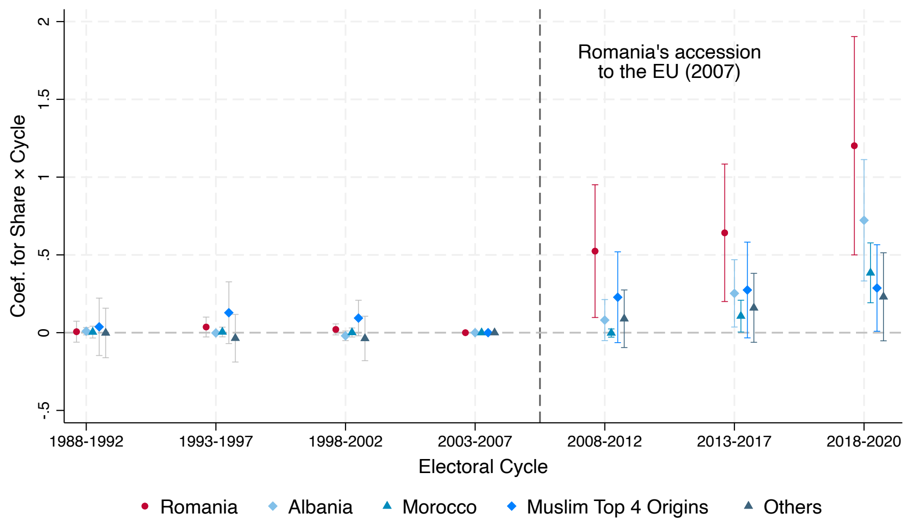
First, the political representation of historically underrepresented groups tends to remain extremely low even after legal enfranchisement. Within the same institutional context – Italian municipal councils – women were severely under-represented prior to the introduction of gender quotas; in the early 1990s, they only represented 5% of councilors.[33] Looking at the same group, namely immigrants, non-British Commonwealth citizens residing in the United Kingdom are entitled to vote and stand for Parliament, yet no Member of Parliament without British nationality has ever been elected.[34] First-generation immigrants, in particular, face additional barriers com-

[32] The positive coefficient is driven largely by Russian-born councilors. However, when we restrict the analysis to Russian-born councilors only, the estimate remains statistically insignificant. We therefore find no evidence that Romanian enfranchisement increased the representation of either Russian-born councilors or non-EU Eastern European councilors more broadly.

[33] Similar patterns in other contexts include the long-standing under-representation of Black Americans in the U.S. Congress until the early 2000s.

[34] Therefore this excludes candidates with multiple citizenships, if they possess the British one.

Figure 3: Probability of Electing a Councilor Born in O by the Municipal Share of Citizens from O



Notes: The graph above plots coefficients from five different regressions using Equation 1; each regression has the same nationality of origin in both the dependent and main independent variables (e.g. likelihood of electing an Albanian-born Councilor, regressed on the 2003 municipal share of Albanians * year dummies). Time is election years collapsed at the electoral cycle level: each municipality appears once per cycle (e.g. all 8,000 municipalities had an election sometime between 2008 and 2012, so elections in these 5 years are pooled in a single electoral cycle). The dependent variable is an indicator variable equal to 1 when the given municipality has a Romanian/Albanian/Moroccan/Next 4 Muslim/Top 18 Others-born councilor in the given year and 0 otherwise. The plotted coefficients are for the interaction terms between electoral cycle dummies and Romanian/Albanian/Moroccan/Next 4 Muslim/Top 18 Others municipal population share, fixed at their 2003 level. The regression separately controls for municipality and year fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the municipality level. Bars represent 95 percent confidence intervals.

pared to previously disenfranchised citizens, including language constraints, shorter exposure to local institutions, limited political networks, etc.

Second, due to the limited number of seats and the use of individual preference votes in municipal elections (see Section 2.2), there is an implicit representation threshold, namely, the minimum vote share required to secure representation. This threshold provides a useful benchmark for our results. In a purely proportional system based on party vote shares, this threshold can be approximated by the inverse of the number of available seats (e.g., with 25 seats, a party would need about 4% of the votes to obtain representation). In our setting, however, there is no Romanian party, only Romanian candidates. Therefore, we aim to define the threshold at the candidate level.

While there is no unique definition of an implicit representation threshold, a natural definition is the minimum share of votes required to guarantee representation to a candidate within a party-list. This can be computed ex-post as the ratio of a party's vote share to the number of seats it wins, which varies mainly between winning and non-winning parties due to the majority bonus.[35]

[35] For instance, in the median municipal election in 2014, the winning party obtained 53% of the vote and was awarded seven council seats (due to the majority bonus) out of ten available seats. Suppose only one other party was running. This implies an implicit threshold of approximately 7.6% for candidates on the winning party's list (0.53/7) and 15.7% for candidates on the losing party's list (0.47/3). This threshold guarantees representation ex-

If all Romanian voters turned out and coordinated on a single co-ethnic candidate, the defined threshold indicates the minimum share of Romanians in the municipal population that would ensure Romanian representation. While winning lists face a lower implicit threshold, access to such lists (typically controlled by incumbents) is limited for new entrants. We therefore focus on the non-winning list threshold as the natural benchmark, as it corresponds to a setting with lower entry barriers and relative absence of gatekeepers (Dancygier et al. 2021).

Using this benchmark, in only 0.08% (0.14%) of elections between 2009 and 2020 does the Romanian population share in 2003 (2006) exceed the non-winning list threshold, whereas Romanian-born candidates are actually elected in 0.46% of elections. This implies a representation effect three to five times larger than the implicit threshold. This result is reversed only when using the time-varying Romanian share, which exceeds the threshold in 1.28% of the elections. However, this last measure severely overestimates the participating Romanian share, as both our results in the following section and the survey evidence in Table A.3 suggest that electoral participation among post-2007 arrivals is low, with voter registration as low as 5%.

5.1.2 Enfranchisement of Pre-existing Immigrants vs. New Arrivals

In this subsection, we disentangle whether the increase in the likelihood of having a Romanian-born councilor is driven by the right extension to the pre-existing Romanian residents or by those who arrived in Italy after 2007. To do so, we use an IV approach and instrument for New_{mt} in equation (2) with the expression in equation (3). The first-stage results are presented in columns (1) and (2) of Table 1. The instrument strongly predicts the share of new Romanians at the municipality-by-year level, thus satisfying the relevance condition. In column (1), we use the time-invariant Romanian share at the 2003 level for $Early_{mt}$, whereas in column (2), we let $Early_{mt}$ equal the current Romanian share in year t up to 2007 and fix the share at the 2007 value from 2008 onward. The former specification is more similar to our specification when looking at Romanian representation, while the latter more precisely matches the number of pre-existing Romanians over time. The coefficient for New_{mt} is positive and statistically significant in both specifications, indicating that the instrument is relevant. Moreover, our instrument is strong as the Kleibergen-Paap F-statistic ranges from 42.70 to 47.74.

Columns (3)-(6) of Table 1 present a comparison of the OLS and 2SLS specifications of equation (2). Columns (3) and (4) show the OLS coefficients, while Columns (5) and (6) report the 2SLS estimates corresponding to the first stage specifications of columns (1) and (2). The OLS estimates are larger for the pre-existing share of Romanians than for the new Romanian arrivals, and they are significant for both. However, once we instrument for the potentially endogenous inflow of new arrivals, the 2SLS estimates for new arrivals are no longer significant, and, if anything, their point estimates turn negative. On the other hand, the effect for the pre-existing share remains significant

post, meaning that there is no feasible allocation of the remaining votes across other candidates within the list that could prevent the candidate from being elected. In practice, the candidate may win a seat with fewer votes depending on how votes are distributed to other candidates.

and positive. These results suggest that the OLS specification overstates the effect of new arrivals, an upward bias that is corrected by the IV strategy. In our preferred specification in column (5), the estimate indicates that a municipality with one more percentage point of early Romanian share increases its likelihood of electing a Romanian-born councilor by 0.47 percentage points.

Table 1: Likelihood of Electing Romanian-Born Councilor

	(1) First Stage	(2) First Stage	(3) OLS	(4) OLS	(5) 2SLS	(6) 2SLS
Dependent Variable:	New Romanian Inflow		Prob. Electing Romanian-Born Councilor			
Romanian share in 2003 × Post2007	0.7581*** (0.0541)		0.271** (0.130)		**0.472*** **(0.276)**	
Early Romanian Share		-0.0385 (0.0574)		0.124*** (0.033)		0.102 (0.106)
Early Romanian Share × Post2007		0.5726*** (0.0431)		0.218** (0.099)		**0.518*** **(0.274)**
Instrument	**0.0068*** **(0.0010)**	**0.0075*** **(0.0011)**				
New Romanian Inflow			0.152** (0.066)	0.133* (0.065)	**-0.117** **(0.336)**	**-0.398** **(0.473)**
Municipality FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Obs	115,887	115,897	115,887	115,897	115,887	115,897
Kleibergen-Paap rk Wald F statistic	42.70	47.74	-	-	-	-
Dep var mean	-	-	0.002	0.002	0.002	0.002

Notes: Columns (1) and (2) from the table above report the first stage results for the 2SLS IV regression in Equation (2). In column (1), we use Romanian share at the 2003 level for $Early_{mt}$; in column (2), we let $Early_{mt}$ equal the current Romanian share in year t up to 2007 and fix the share at the 2007 share from 2008 onward. Columns (3)-(6) present a comparison between the OLS and 2SLS specifications of Equation 2. Columns (3) and (4) show the OLS results, while columns (5) and (6) are the 2SLS results that correspond to the first stage in columns (1) and (2). Standard errors clustered by municipality in parentheses. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

The survey on Romanian immigrants in Italy from WIIW (2012), weighted for national representation, shows that 23.9% of Romanian immigrants who arrived between 2004 and 2006 were registered to vote, compared with only 5.4% of those arriving between 2007 and 2010. These patterns corroborate our main findings.[36] Overall, we conclude that the increase in Romanian-born representation is driven primarily by the extension of rights to Romanians who were already in Italy before 2007.

5.1.3 Mechanisms: Distinguishing Supply and Demand of Romanian-born Politicians

In this section, we discuss the mechanisms behind the increase in the likelihood of electing a Romanian-born councilor. Among the rights acquired with EU citizenship (Section 2.1), enfranchisement is conceptually the most relevant dimension for political representation. Moreover, it is the only channel whose timing is precisely consistent with the pattern in Figure 2, due to the electoral cycle and the bureaucratic delays faced by Romanian voters.

While Romanians gained full access to the labor market only in 2012 and fast-track citizenship

[36] The unweighted percentages of registered to vote are 23.5% and 5.3%, respectively.

only in 2014, the main increase in representation begins earlier, around 2009. By contrast, the extension of residency rights took effect immediately in 2007. This timing inconsistency suggests that enfranchisement was at least a necessary condition for the observed effect, although it may be sufficient only if combined with residency rights. Importantly, Section 5.1.2 shows that both the extension of residency and voting rights only affected the pre-existing immigrant population, ruling out the possibility that the effect was driven by compositional changes due to new arrivals.

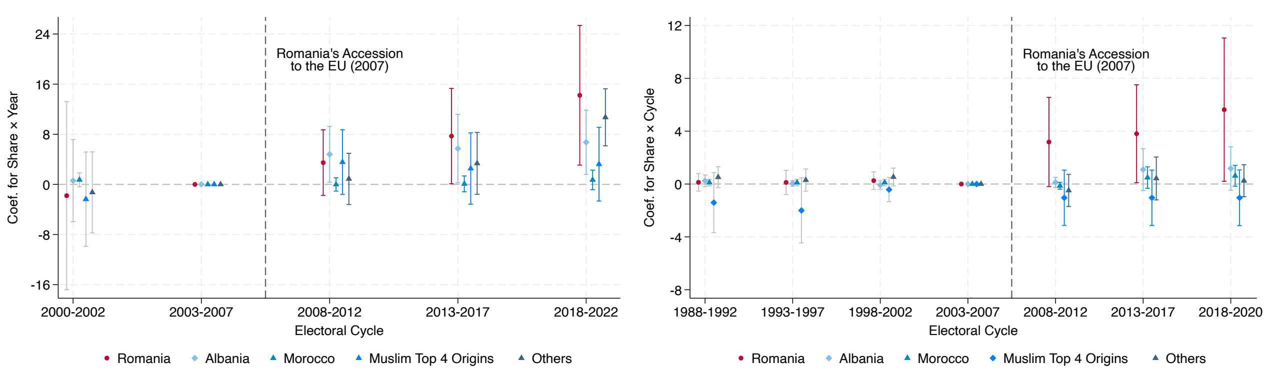
Even conditional on enfranchisement being a necessary channel for representation, the effect is still consistent with different underlying mechanisms. At one extreme, granting eligibility to run in local elections could lead to a sharp increase in the supply of Romanian-born candidates. In this case, even with a stable success rate, a larger number of candidates would mechanically translate into more elected officials. At the other extreme, enfranchisement may operate through demand-side effects: as Romanian immigrants gain voting rights, a fixed number of Romanian-born candidates may become more successful due to a more favorable electorate.

Supply of Romanian-born Candidates We begin by examining the effect of EU enlargement on the supply of Romanian-born candidates. Unfortunately, administrative data on municipal candidates who were not elected are not available in Italy. Instead, some municipalities maintain records of past elections, often in the form of hard-copy candidate rosters. As a result, we rely on an original dataset constructed through the manual collection and digitization of candidate rosters from municipalities that responded to our data request and possessed records for at least one election before 2008 and at least two elections thereafter.

Figure 4: Likelihood of Candidacy vs. Success (Subsample with Complete Candidacy Data)

(a) Probability of Immigrant Candidate

(b) Probability of Immigrant Councilor



Notes: Each graph above plots the coefficients from five different regressions using Equation 1; each regression has the same nationality of origin in both the dependent and main independent variables. Election years are collapsed at the electoral cycle level. The plotted coefficients are for the interaction terms between immigrants' share fixed at its 2003 level and time dummies. The dependent variable is an indicator equal to 1 when the given municipality has a Romanian-born, Albanian-born, Moroccan-born candidate in the given year, and 0 otherwise (same logic applies for candidates born in the next four largest Muslim countries of origin - in order Bangladesh, Pakistan, Egypt, Tunisia - or the residual category of largest countries of origin). The regression controls for municipality and year fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the municipality level. The sample contains the 333 municipalities for which we have data on the name and birthplace of all municipal candidates. Bars represent 95 percent confidence intervals.

Figure 4a presents the event-study estimation of equation (1), using the number of immigrant *candidates* as our outcome. The figure shows an increase in Romanian-born candidates over time; however, we observe a very similar increase for Albanian-born candidates and for candidates born in the residual largest 18 countries of origin. Only the number of Moroccan-born candidates and candidates born in the residual four largest Muslim-majority countries remain fairly stable.[37] This pattern is at odds with the elected-councilor results in Figure 3; the difference is even clearer when we restrict the elected-councilor analysis to the same subsample of 333 municipalities for which we observe the universe of candidates, in Figure 4b. Comparing Figure 4a and Figure 4b, which use the same subsample, we observe that the increase in success rates following 2007 is unique to Romanian-born candidates, while the increase in candidacy rates is common across other (non-Muslim) immigrant groups. These results indicate that the increase in the number of elected councilors is not solely driven by a change in candidate supply.

Romanian Turnout One natural explanation for the increased electoral success of Romanian-born candidates is the expansion of their potential voter base following the enfranchisement of Romanians. To assess whether this mechanism was indeed at work, we investigate whether newly enfranchised Romanians registered and effectively turned out to vote. While Italian citizens are automatically eligible to vote, residents from other EU member states must register before participating in elections for the first time. Unfortunately, municipality-level nationality-specific registration data (as in Bratsberg et al. (2021)) are not available in Italy before 2011. To overcome this limitation, we exploit the fact that only Italian citizens are eligible to vote in regional elections and focus on the cases in which regional and municipal elections were held simultaneously. We estimate the following regression:

$$DifVoters_{mt} = b_0 + \big[\sum_s b_s ImSh_m^{2003} \times \mathbb{1}_t\{t = s\}\big] + \eta_m + \theta_t + e_{mt}. \tag{4}$$

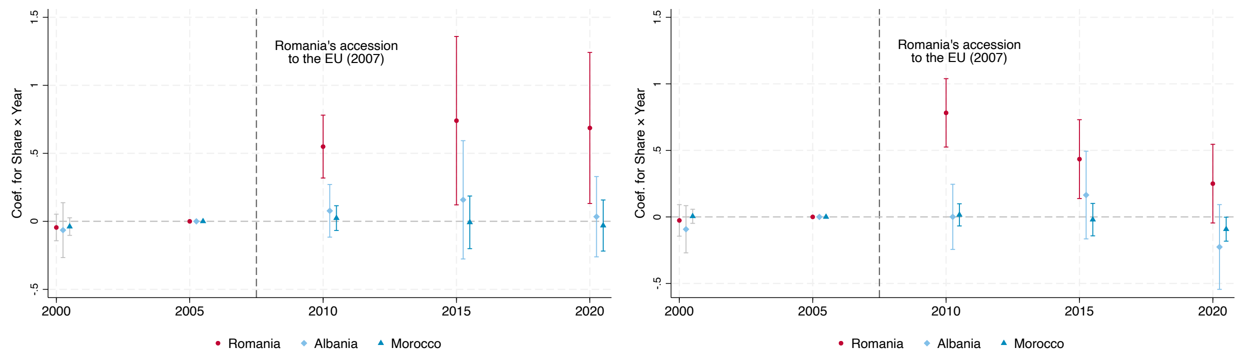
The dependent variable $DifVoters_{mt}$ is the difference in the number of registered voters (or votes cast) from municipality m, between municipal and regional elections. We normalize this difference by municipal population because more populous municipalities would otherwise mechanically show a larger difference. In a subset of municipalities, municipal and regional elections were held on the

[37]The stagnation in the number of Moroccan-born, and to some extent other Muslim-origin, candidates may be driven by several factors. First, voter bias against Muslim candidates may have discouraged their political participation. For example, Madrid et al. (2022) finds that voters evaluate candidates from religious out-groups more negatively, while Colussi et al. (2021) shows that the salience of Muslim minorities increases negative attitudes toward Muslims. Although Albania also has a substantial Muslim population, Muslims account for only about half of the country's population; moreover, Albania has largely embraced secularism, particularly following decades of communist rule (Vickers 2011; Tokrri et al. 2021; Abazi 2022), whereas Islam is constitutionally recognized as the state religion in all five Muslim-majority countries. Second, these Muslim-majority countries consistently scored lower than both Romania and Albania on the Economist Intelligence Unit's Democracy Index throughout most of the period under study (see, for example, Morocco in Figure A.15). Tunisia is the only exception, exceeding Albania's score between 2012 and 2020, although it is also the origin country with the smallest immigrant population in Italy. Lower levels of democratic development may reflect weaker traditions of electoral participation, potentially contributing to the lower candidacy rates observed among immigrants from these countries.

same day in 2000, 2005, 2010, 2015, and 2020.[38] Municipality and year fixed effects are included.

Figure 5: Difference in Voters b/w Municipal and Regional Elections, % of Municipal Population

(a) Difference in Registered Voters (b) Difference in Actual Votes



Notes: The graph in panel (a) plots coefficients for interaction terms between immigrant share of interest at its 2003 level and year dummies, as in equation 4. The dependent variable is the difference in the number of registered voters, as a percentage of the municipality population, between municipal and regional elections. The dependent variable for the graph in panel (b) is the difference between the number of actual voters in municipal elections and that in regional elections. In both graphs, the red dot refers to the regression where Romanians are the relevant immigrant group, whereas the light blue diamond and the blue triangle correspond to separate regressions where the immigrant shares of interest are Albanians and Moroccans, respectively. We restrict the analysis to the main cycle of regional elections: a five-year interval between 2000 and 2020. Bars represent 95 percent confidence intervals.

If Romanians chose to register and vote following enfranchisement, we should observe a divergence in the number of registered voters and votes cast between municipal elections (where they were eligible to vote) and regional elections (where they were not), after 2007, particularly in municipalities with larger Romanian communities. This is exactly what we find. Figures 5a and 5b report the b_s coefficients for registered voters and votes cast, respectively. Starting in 2010 – the first election following enfranchisement – we observe a positive and statistically significant discrepancy in both measures, concentrated in municipalities with a higher share of Romanian residents. In terms of magnitude, a one-percentage-point increase in the 2003 municipal share of Romanians increased municipal registration and turnout by about 0.5 percentage points.[39]

[38]The exact dates are April 26, 2000; April 3, 2005; March 28, 2010; May 31, 2015; and September 20, 2020. We exclude municipalities whose municipal and regional elections overlapped in 2013, 2014, 2019 because, being off-cycle, the sample would be a repeated cross section, rather than a panel.

[39]Because the independent variables correspond to the fixed share of the Romanian population in 2003, the precise interpretation of the coefficient is not straightforward. At face value, the coefficient suggests that a one-percentage-point increase in Romanians as a share of the 2003 municipal population increased municipal registration by 0.5 percentage points (and virtually the same effect on turnout). However, the share of Romanians in 2003 corresponds to a larger share in the following years, when we measure the electoral returns. Therefore, the actual estimates are likely smaller than the initial interpretation. A regression of the Romanian population share in 2015 on its share in 2003 suggests that a 1 percentage point increase in the latter is associated with an approximately 2.1 percentage point increase in the former (estimates are similar in 2010 or 2020). Combining this with the reduced-form effect of 0.5 percentage points implies a registration and turnout rate of roughly 23% (i.e., 0.5/2.1). This estimate is broadly consistent with aggregate data. In 2015, approximately 80,000 Romanians were registered to vote in Italy, representing roughly 10% of the overage Romanian population. The survey evidence in Table A.3 helps reconcile this puzzle: registration rates measured in 2010 were about 24% among Romanians who migrated between 2004-2006, but only 5% among those who arrived later. This suggests that newly arrived immigrants (the absolute majority, as of 2015) had very low registration rates, which instead increases with length of residence. The estimate should

For several reasons, we view these results as highly compelling and difficult to reconcile with alternative mechanisms. First, in the municipalities we study, voters enter the polling station and simultaneously receive the ballots for both the municipal and regional elections whenever they are eligible to vote in both. Any confounding mechanism would therefore need to explain why native voters selectively abstained from regional elections, while still voting in municipal elections, only after 2007 and only in municipalities with larger Romanian populations. Second, the placebo estimates for Albanians and Moroccans are close to zero and statistically insignificant. This rules out a more general response to immigrant presence. An alternative explanation would require native voters to abstain from regional elections specifically in response to the presence of Romanians, and only after Romanian enfranchisement. Third, while it is difficult to conceive of a reason why native voters would abstain from voting only for the regional election and only in response to enfranchisement of Romanians, such a mechanism could in principle affect the number of votes cast. However, we observe similar effects for voter registrations as well, which measure the number of individuals entitled to vote in a municipality. In Italy, native voters do not register themselves; rather, municipalities automatically maintain electoral rolls. This is thus independent of voters' behavior. Still, we observe a large discrepancy in registrations as well. Taken together, these findings leave little room for alternative explanations and strongly suggest that the observed effects reflect increased registration and turnout among Romanian citizens following enfranchisement.

Competitive Elections The evidence that Romanians turned out to vote also suggests that these newly enfranchised voters may have become pivotal in municipalities with sizable Romanian populations and in which elections were expected to be close, in line with research on group mobilization (Shertzer 2016). We focus on municipalities in which close elections were anticipated based on prior electoral competitiveness and run the following specification:

$$\begin{aligned} C^o_{mc} &= a_0 + a_1 Com_{mc} + \sum_{s=1,\dots,5}\left[b_s Cycle_s \times Com_{mc}\right] + \sum_{o\in\mathbb{O}}\Big\{c^o ImSh^{o,2003} \times Com_{mc} \\ &+ \sum_{s=1,\dots,5}\left[d^o_s ImSh^{o,2003} \times Cycle_s\right] + \sum_{s=1,\dots,5}\left[e^o_s ImSh^{o,2003} \times Cycle_s \times Com_{mc}\right]\Big\} + \eta_m + \theta_t + \tilde{\varepsilon}_{mc} \end{aligned} \tag{5}$$

Here, C^o_{mc} is an indicator equal to 1 if municipality m in electoral cycle c has a councilor born in origin country o. Considering Romania's accession in 2007 and the 5-year cycle in municipal elections, we define the cycles around 2007 to include 5 years of observations. The variable Com_{mc} is an indicator equal to 1 if municipality m had a competitive election in cycle $c-1$. We define a competitive election as one where the vote-share gap between the top two parties is less than 5 percentage points. The origin countries considered in this specification are again $\mathbb{O}$ ={Romania, Albania, Morocco}. We include municipality and cycle fixed effects, respectively η_m and θ_c.

therefore be interpreted as indicating that a one-percentage-point increase in the 2003 Romanian population share generates up to a 50% registration rate *among Romanian migrants present in Italy in 2003.*

We hypothesize that if political parties anticipate a tight election, they are more likely to include minority candidates in their list of councilor candidates to gain votes from enfranchised minority constituents, especially in municipalities where minority communities are large. The coefficient e_s^o for the triple interaction term $ImSh^{o,2003} \times Cycle_s \times Com_{mc}$ for each cycle is shown in Figure *A*.14. We see a significant increase in the likelihood of having a Romanian-born councilor in municipalities that were expecting competitive elections in the 2013–2017 electoral cycles, as the Romanian share of the population rises. The effect on the other two post-2007 cycles is positive but non-significant. We do not find any effect in our placebo specifications in which the dependent variable is the likelihood of having an Albanian-born or Moroccan-born councilor. Table A.7 shows the corresponding coefficient estimates and confirms a positive and significant triple-interaction term for Romanians, and virtually no effect for the other groups.

Finally, we analyze the partisan affiliation of elected Romanian-born councilors. The political orientation of these councilors is illustrated in Table *A*.8. There is no statistical difference between Romanian-born and non-Romanian-born councilors in terms of ideological affiliation. However, Romanian-born councilors are significantly more likely to belong to the winning party than the non-Romanian-born councilors. Interestingly, Romanian-born councilors were initially significantly less likely to belong to the winning party but, over time, they became significantly more likely to be elected in the ruling parties' lists.

5.2 Effect of EU Citizenship on Prosocial Behavior

Proponents of expanding immigrant rights argue that extending the franchise to resident immigrants and ensuring more secure residency status would increase sense of belonging and civic participation, thus benefiting the entire community. However, the literature only provides evidence on these effects in the context of naturalization (Hainmueller et al. 2017), while very little is known about the effects of more limited expansions of rights, such as the acquisition of EU citizenship. We test whether prosocial behavior, and consent to organ donation in particular, increases when Romanian immigrants obtain EU citizenship.

We focus on consent to organ donation for several reasons. First, explicit pre-registered consent matters in its own right as it is crucial for increasing the supply of organs available to patients in need (Bac 2026), particularly in light of the long waiting times observed across Europe. Second, the literature has used consent to organ donation as a proxy for prosocial attitudes and social capital.[40] While expressing consent does not entail monetary or health costs, medical evidence points to non-negligible psychological costs associated with the decision (Carola et al. 2023; Buffat et al. 2020). Moreover, individuals in our data must actively opt in, a bureaucratic friction often sufficient to discourage action (Perez-Vincent 2023). We therefore interpret consent to organ donation as

[40] Putnam (2000) and Guiso et al. (2004) use blood donation, while Bartscher et al. (2021) use blood and organ donation, along with other measures, to capture social capital. According to the Oxford English Dictionary, social capital refers to *the interpersonal networks and common civic values which influence the infrastructure and economy of a particular society; the nature, extent, or value of these.*

arising when prosocial motives outweigh these costs. Finally, the AIDO database provides granular information on individuals who have registered as potential organ donors, including both their place of birth and municipality of residence at the time of registration.

Consent to donation does not involve the citizen–representative duality that characterizes elections. Since we directly observe the number of new consents expressed by Romanian-born individuals in each municipality and year, we can estimate the treatment effect on Romanians' behavior directly by controlling for the local Romanian population. We thus estimate the following equation:

$$DonorConsent_{mt} = \mu_0 + \mu_1 ImmigCount_{mt} + \Big[\sum_{s=2003}^{2018} \pi_s \mathbb{1}_t\{t = s\}\Big] + \eta_m + \nu_{mt} \tag{6}$$

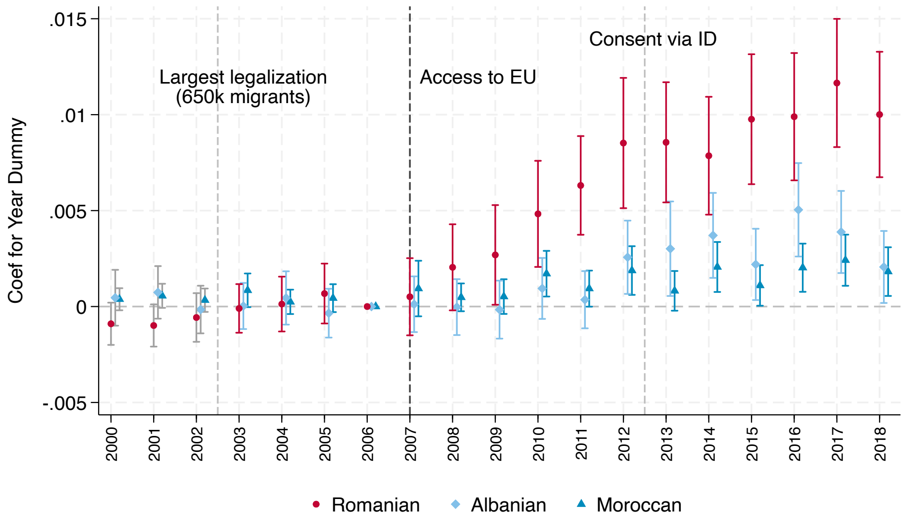
The outcome variable is the number of immigrants from a given country (Romania, Albania, Morocco) who registered as organ donors in municipality m in year t. We control for the time-variant municipal count of Romanians (Albanians, Moroccans) to rule out the possibility of a mechanical increase in the number of donors following an increase in the total number of Romanians (Albanians, Moroccans) after 2007. We analyze the coefficients of the year dummies to assess whether the number of consents increased after 2007.

The event-study analysis is presented in Figure 6. We find a significant increase in the number of Romanian immigrants registering as potential organ donors, even after controlling for the total number of Romanian immigrants in each municipality, suggesting that the increase is not driven by mechanical compositional effects. In contrast, we do not observe a significant increase in the number of Albanian or Moroccan-born individuals registering as potential organ donors after 2007. This suggests that the rise in organ-donation consent is specific to Romanian-born residents and does not reflect a broader trend among immigrants. The coefficients for the year dummies in the specification for Romanians show a gradual increase over the first five years following Romania's EU accession, averaging 0.003, before stabilizing at an average value of 0.009 in the subsequent five years. In absolute terms, this implies that while only 56 new Romanian donors registered between 2004 and 2006 across Italy, 386 did so in 2016-2018. Although consent levels remain much lower among Romanians than among Italians in absolute terms (approximately 16,000 new Italian consents in 2006 and 22,000 in 2017), this gap reduced considerably once population size is taken into account, as the Italian population in 2017 is roughly 50 times larger than the Romanian one.[41] Moreover, consents among Romanians in 2016–2018 exceed those of the next five largest immigrant groups in Italy, despite the latter having a combined population roughly 50 percent larger.

To the best of our knowledge, no specific campaign on organ donation was implemented in Romania or targeted at Romanians in Italy in 2007. One potential threat to identification is that a large share of Albanians and Moroccans are Muslim, whereas the majority of Romanians are Orthodox Christian. If Muslims are systematically less likely to donate than Orthodox Christians,

[41] To account for potential changes in overall donation trends, Figure A.17 uses the ratio of immigrant to native donors as the outcome, the results show the relative increase in the rate of Romanian consents compared to natives.

Figure 6: Effect of EU Citizenship on Consent to Organ Donation



Notes: The graphs above illustrate the coefficients for year dummies in $DonorConsent_{mt} = \mu_0 + \mu_1 ImmigCount_{mt} + [\sum_{s=2003}^{2018} \pi_s \mathbb{1}_t\{t = s\}] + \eta_m + \nu_{mt}$ where standard errors are clustered by municipality. In three different regressions, the dependent variable is the number of consents given by those who were born in Romania, Albania, and Morocco respectively, in a given municipality and year. The variable $ImmigCount_{mt}$ corresponds to the number of residents in a given municipality and year who are nationals of Romania, Albania, and Morocco respectively in accordance with the dependent variable. We only have data for $ImmigCount_{mt}$ between 2003-2018. To obtain the 3 years leading up to 2003, we performed a linear extrapolation, in which negative values from the extrapolation were set to zero. Bars represent 95 percent confidence intervals.

and if an unrelated confounder affected donation behavior in 2007, this could potentially explain the divergent trends we observe. To rule this out, we conduct an additional placebo analysis using large immigrant groups in Italy from Eastern European countries with predominantly Orthodox populations that did not join the EU, namely Russians, Ukrainians, and Moldovans. The treated group consists of Romanians and Bulgarians, the two immigrant groups that acquired EU citizenship rights in 2007. The results, shown in Figure A.16, again indicate that the effect on donation is specific to groups that acquired EU citizenship. The absence of a comparable effect for Moldovans is particularly reassuring for two reasons. First, approximately 80% of Moldovans speak Romanian and Romanian-language media are widely available in Moldova, making it unlikely that cultural changes at origin drive the results. Second, Moldovans experienced an increase in migration to Italy proportional to that of Romanians, despite not joining the EU.

Figure 6 also displays two important features. First, the Italian ID card application process eventually began including a question asking applicants to consent to organ donation, creating an alternative channel for registration outside AIDO. However, the disproportionate increase among Romanians occurs before 2013, suggesting that the introduction of consent through ID cards, if anything, may have reduced the growth in AIDO registrations, since our data do not capture consent provided through ID cards. Second, the lack of any increase in consent for donations following

2002–2003, when the largest legalization program of undocumented immigrants in Italian history was enacted and almost 700,000 undocumented immigrants—mostly Romanians, Albanians, and Moroccans—gained legal status. This suggests that the increase in the organ-donation registration rate among Romanians in 2007 is not driven by undocumented immigrants gaining legal status and that the extension of voting rights may have played an important role.

One potential concern is that controlling for the number of immigrants by group may not be sufficient. The appropriate outcome variable might instead be the share of each immigrant group that consents to organ donation, rather than the total number. However, using the share as an outcome variable could also be problematic for the same reason. That is, a large influx of Romanians after 2007 would mechanically lower the share of Romanians who are donors, as newly arrived immigrants may need time to consider and understand how to register as donors. Figure A.18 shows the results using the share rather than the number as an outcome. The figure reveals both effects. We observe a sharp drop in the share of Romanians giving consent immediately after 2007, consistent with the sharp immigrant inflow raising the denominator. However, shortly thereafter, we see a fast increase in the share of Romanian donors, even as the denominator continues to rise. In contrast, we do not observe similar trends among Albanians or Moroccans.

Finally, we replicate the IV analysis in Section 4.2 to assess whether our findings are driven by pre-existing immigrants or by new arrivals. To do so, we depart from Equation (6), back to the specification in Equation (2), using organ-donation consent as the outcome variable. This change is necessary because identifying this margin requires treating the Romanian population as the independent variable of interest rather than as a control. In this specification, the coefficient captures the marginal effect of a one-percentage-point increase in the Romanian population, separately for pre-2007 immigrants and new arrivals. The results of this exercise are reported in Table A.9, where the dependent variables are, respectively, the total number of Romanian-born donors and the share of donors among Romanian immigrants. As expected, results are entirely driven by Romanians who already were in Italy before 2007, while new arrivals enter with a negative coefficient. This suggests that consenting to organ donation is unlikely to be a priority for newly arrived immigrants, but can be raised through the expansion of rights among individuals who have resided in the host country for a longer period without such rights.

Unlike the electoral results, which emerge two years after accession, the increase in organ-donation consents starts immediately. This suggests that it was driven by Romanian citizens regardless of their representation. Indeed, when interacting year dummies with an indicator for having Romanian-born councilors, we see positive but statistically insignificant results (Figure A.19).

5.3 Effect of EU Citizenship on Political Orientation and Local Public Spending

A common finding in the literature is that immigrant presence generates a native backlash, reflected in both voting and public spending choices (Barone et al. 2016; Ferwerda 2021). This raises the question of whether EU citizenship can mitigate such electoral and fiscal backlash. Such an effect may arise either through the direct political participation of newly enfranchised immigrants or through greater acceptance of the group as part of a shared European identity.

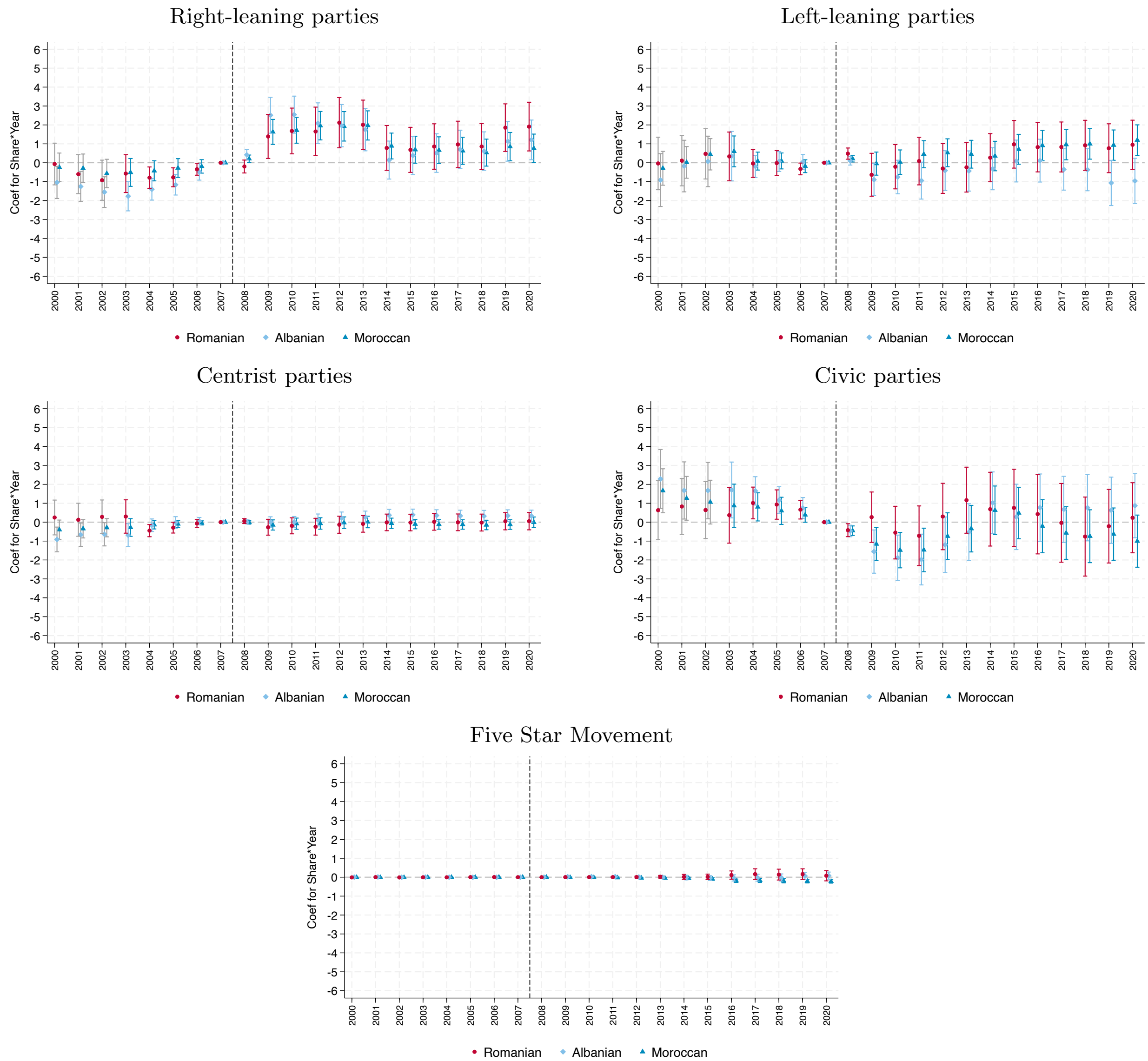
Political Orientation In Italy, most right-leaning parties maintained anti-immigration positions at the national level during our observation period, and even those not explicitly anti-immigrant were often in coalition with right-wing parties holding such positions. Indeed, Barone et al. (2016) find that an increase in the share of immigrants raises the likelihood of electing a right-wing mayor. In this subsection, we therefore investigate whether enfranchising the largest immigrant community offsets the increase in support for right-wing mayoral candidates documented by Barone et al. (2016). Specifically, we use Equation 1 to analyze how the ideology of the winning party in municipal elections changed following 2007. The party or coalition that wins the election expresses the mayor and the majority of councilors; therefore, examining the winning party provides a measure of how the municipality voted and of who gained control of local government.

We categorize the parties into five different categories: right-leaning, centrist, left-leaning, civic, and Five Star Movement. To classify the parties into these five categories, we analyze their name and their Wikipedia page. We classify a party as left-leaning when: (1) the term *Left (Sinistra)* appears in the name; (2) the party participates in a coalition with a party that has traditionally been categorized as left-leaning, such as the Democratic Party (Partito Democratico); or (3) the party is categorized as left-leaning by Wikipedia. Similarly, we classify a party as right-leaning when: (1) the term *Right (Destra)* appears in the name; (2) the party participates in a coalition with a party that has traditionally been categorized as right-leaning, such as Forza Italia; or (3) the party is categorized as right-leaning by Wikipedia. The centrist parties are those that are not in a coalition with any parties classified as left- or right-leaning and contain the term *Centro*, such as the Unione di Centro. Finally, a party is considered civic if it is not in a coalition with any party classified as left- or right-leaning and contains either the word *Civico* or *Indipendente*.

Figure 7 shows that the likelihood of a right-leaning party winning in municipal elections increases over time in municipalities that are home to more immigrants from any of the three largest immigrant communities—Romanian, Albanian, or Moroccan. Since the pattern is very similar across all three groups, even though Romanians gained voting rights and the other two groups did not, this suggests that the enfranchisement of Romanians in itself did not cause the ideology of the winning party to change. Instead, the presence of any immigrant community, whether it had the franchise or not, played a greater role. We observe a slight decrease in the likelihood of civic parties winning for a few years after 2007, but the likelihood returns to its previous level soon after. We do not observe any significant and consistent patterns for the other types of parties.

Local Public Finance Research studying women's suffrage and the U.S. Voting Rights Act has found a significant change in public finance after the franchise was extended to a new subset of

Figure 7: Effect of EU Citizenship on Political Orientation



Notes: The graphs above plot the coefficients from the event study for the interaction terms between the immigrant share of interest fixed at its 2003 level and year dummies. The red dot refers to the regression in which the immigrant share of interest is the Romanian share whereas the light blue diamond and the blue triangle correspond to separate regressions where the immigrant share of interest is the Albanian and Moroccan share, respectively. The dependent variable is an indicator variable equal to 1 when the winning party in the municipal election has a political ideology mentioned in the title of each graph and 0 otherwise. The regression separately controls for municipality and year fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the municipality level. Bars represent 95 percent confidence intervals.

the population.[42] We examine whether there are any distinct patterns in local public finance for municipalities with more Romanians after their rights expanded. First, we look at the evolution

[42]See Lott and Kenny (1999), Abrams and Settle (1999), Washington (2008), Aidt and Dallal (2008), Funk and Gathmann (2015), Cascio and Shenhav (2020), and Kose et al. (2020) on how women's suffrage led to a change in budget allocation and Cascio and Washington (2014) on how the Voting Rights Act influenced government transfers.

of the property tax and waste tax as shares of total revenue for each municipality to see whether the tax burden on homeowners changes.[43] Figure A.20 shows an increase in the property tax and a decrease in the waste tax over time in municipalities with more Romanians compared to those with fewer. However, we do not see any statistical difference between municipalities with more Romanians and those with more Albanians or Moroccans. Consequently, we conclude that the local tax-revenue composition is unaffected by extending voting rights to Romanian immigrants.

We then investigate the breakdown of expenditure. In Figure A.21, we present an event-study analysis of the expenditure shares of five main categories of local expenditure: education, public housing, public security, social programs, and transportation. Once again, we do not observe a statistical difference between municipalities with more Romanians and those with more Albanians or Moroccans. We find that in municipalities with a large presence of at least one of the three immigrant communities, the expenditure share on public security increases over time and the expenditure share on social programs decreases. This finding is consistent with the increase in the likelihood of a right-leaning party or coalition winning the municipal election when there is a large presence of any of the three immigrant communities considered.

6 Interpretation

Romania's accession to the European Union is, to our knowledge, the only shock that occurred in 2007 that specifically and differentially affected Romanian (and Bulgarian) immigrants living in Italy. We are thus confident that our identification strategies correctly capture this event. However, the event inherently involves several simultaneous changes that are challenging to disentangle. These changes include the enfranchisement of Romanians for municipal elections, more secure and easily obtained residency status, free movement of labor, and the legalization of undocumented immigrants. The expansion of these rights also led to an increase in the number of Romanians moving to Italy. In this section, we discuss how we address the multiple confounding events in our analyses, and why we think that enfranchisement and residency rights are the key dimensions.

First, our IV approach ensures that the results are driven by pre-existing Romanian immigrants rather than by the new, potentially differently selected, Romanian immigrants. Second, we rule out that the effects are driven by the simple legalization of Romanians. The accession of Romania to the EU indirectly legalized irregular Romanian immigrants in Italy (Mastrobuoni and Pinotti 2015). However, 2007 was not the first wave of legalization of Romanian immigrants. As discussed above, Italy legalized a large share of its undocumented immigrant population in 2003, accounting for nearly 700,000 individuals, predominantly Romanians, Albanians, and Moroccans. The fact that none of our results show any evidence of a jump in 2003, especially in Figure 3 and Figure 6, suggests that legalization did not play a major role in fostering representation and prosocial behavior. Similarly, the fact that our results are entirely driven by the pre-existing Romanian population,

[43] In 2016, 20 percent of foreigners owned a house compared to 77 percent of Italians.

while previously undocumented immigrants legalized via EU citizenship would be measured as new arrivals, further suggests that our findings are not driven by legalization.

Third, evidence is consistent with effects on the labor market for Romanians not being a key driver. The gradual process of Romania's EU accession alleviates some of our concerns, since the labor market restrictions for Romanians in Italy were not lifted until January 1, 2012. Instead, we observe effects on representation beginning in 2009 and effects on prosocial behavior starting in 2007. Table A.2 shows significant evidence of changes in Romanian employment only for a few sectors. The largest change is the increase in the number of Romanians seeking a job, which seems unable to explain the increase in local representation and prosocial behavior. Since the municipal councilor's position is virtually unpaid and requires little time commitment, it is very unlikely that higher unemployment among newly arrived Romanians facilitated their election.

As a result, our findings likely reflect a combination of enfranchisement, enhanced residency security, and potentially a stronger sense of belonging associated with a shared European identity. When considering municipal representation as the outcome, enfranchisement logically appears to be the most relevant and necessary mechanism. At the same time, the fact that both the effects for representation and prosocial behavior are driven by pre-existing immigrants – who already had some limited form of residency rights – suggests that voting rights may play a central role. However, we cannot rule out the possibility that the perception of having more secure and long-term residency, not dependent on job stability, and a stronger sense of belonging through "feeling more European" also contribute to the observed effects, particularly in the case of prosocial behavior.

7 Conclusion

We study how expanding immigrants' voting and residency rights through the acquisition of EU citizenship affects political representation, prosocial behavior, the ideological orientation of the winning party, and local public finances. Exploiting Romania's accession to the European Union in 2007, we find that the likelihood of electing a Romanian-born councilor increases in municipalities with a larger share of Romanian immigrants. The effect is specific to Romanians, as we see no comparable effects among Albanians or Moroccans, the second and third largest immigrant communities in Italy, or other immigrant groups. Using an IV approach, we find that this effect is driven by the pre-existing Romanian population, rather than by newly arrived Romanians.

To explore the underlying mechanisms, we first show that the supply of Romanian-born candidates increased, but by a magnitude comparable to that observed for other non-Muslim immigrant groups, while Romanian-born candidates became systematically more successful. We also find evidence of increased voter turnout among Romanian citizens and of a stronger effect on representation when elections are expected to be competitive. This suggests that political parties became more inclined to include minority candidates on their lists to attract the (ethnic) vote of enfranchised immigrants.

The effects of expanding immigrants' rights extend beyond political outcomes. In particular, we observe an increase in prosocial behavior, proxied by consent to organ donation, among Romanians after Romania's EU accession. The IV analysis shows that this effect is also driven by Romanians who arrived before 2007.

In terms of the winning party's ideology and local public finance, we find no significant differences between municipalities with more Romanian residents and those with more Albanians or Moroccans, our comparison groups, after 2007. In all municipalities with substantial immigrant populations, a higher share of immigrants is associated with a greater likelihood of a right-leaning party victory, increased spending on public security, and reduced spending on social programs.

Our results have important policy implications. First, they shed light on how further expansions of the European Union – including, for instance the Balkan countries or Ukraine – could affect these immigrants' political representation and prosocial behavior in current EU member states. Second, they show that even limited expansions of voting and residency rights for immigrants, a faster and typically more politically feasible policy tool for governments than naturalization reforms, may promote integration without dramatically affecting local political orientation. We believe that future research should further investigate how the political preferences of newly enfranchised groups may differ from those of communities without voting rights and study the effects on public spending that more directly target different ethnic communities.

During the preparation of this work the authors used ChatGPT and Claude to improve grammar, spelling, and readability. After using this tool, the authors reviewed and edited the content as needed and take full responsibility for the content of the published article.

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Online Appendix

Appendix Tables

Table A.1: Cities with Romanian presence: above median vs below median Romanian share

	Low Romanian Mean	High Romanian Mean	Difference	p-value
Population	6260.769	8588.120	-2327.351***	0.000
Share Romanians citizens	0.007	0.020	-0.013***	0.000
Share foreigners (Top counties)	0.009	0.020	-0.010***	0.000
Share Albanian citizens	0.003	0.009	-0.005***	0.000
Share Moroccan citizens	0.005	0.011	-0.005***	0.000
Observations	25202			

Notes: The table above reports the demographic characteristics of municipalities with a share of Romanian population higher or lower than the median value (measured in 2003). Period 2003-2018, each municipality only appears in the election year.

Table A.2: Characteristic Comparison Between Pre-existing and Newly Arrived Romanians, Employment Share of Romanian Immigrants by Sector

Arrival in Italy:	2004-2006	2007-2010	Difference
Agriculture, hunting, and forestry	0.0110	0.0144	0.0073
Construction	0.2019	0.2429	0.0410
Domestic services for families	0.1372	0.1575	0.0204
Education	0.0053	0	-0.0053
Financial intermediaries	0.0042	0	-0.0042
Healthcare and other social services	0.0476	0.0424	-0.0052
Hotels and restaurants	0.0618	0.0328	-0.0290**
Manufacturing	0.1070	0.0570	-0.0500***
Other public social services	0.0138	0.0140	0.0002
Public administration and defense	0.0004	0	-0.0004
Professional and entrepreneurial activities	0.0625	0.0453	-0.0171
Transportation and distribution	0.0373	0.0472	0.0099
Wholesale and retail trade	0.2250	0.1867	-0.0383
Staying at home or looking after children	0.0197	0.0332	0.01352
Student	0.0273	0.0410	0.0137
Looking for work	0.0102	0.0716	0.0614***
Other	0.0279	0.0141	-0.0138

Notes: The table displays the employment share of Romanian immigrants by sector divided into two groups—Romanian immigrants that arrived in Italy during 2004-2006 and those that arrived during 2007-2011, which is after Romania's accession to the EU. The statistics come from the survey on Romanian immigrants in large Italian cities (Milan, Turin and Rome) before and after the EU Accession, provided by WIIW. We use the national weights given by WIIW for this table to show the nationally representative characteristics of Romanian immigrants.

Table A.3: Comparison Between Pre-existing and Newly Arrived Romanians, Socio-demographic Characteristics

Arrival in Italy:	2004-2006	2007-2010	Difference
16-24	0.1044	0.2158	0.1113***
25-34	0.3746	0.3710	-0.0037
35-44	0.3654	0.2885	-0.0768**
45+	0.1556	0.1247	-0.0309
Married	0.6058	0.4927	-0.1131***
Single	0.1438	0.2761	0.1323***
Living with Partner	0.1266	0.1171	-.0095
Divorced	0.1048	0.0903	-0.0145
Widowed	0.0191	0.0239	0.0047
Has dependent children	0.5031	0.4193	-0.0838**
Primary	0.0352	0.0694	0.0342**
Vocational	0.2651	0.2921	0.0268
Secondary	0.4611	0.4209	-0.0405
College	0.1149	0.0775	-0.0375*
Graduate Degree	0.1237	0.1401	0.0162
Less than 400 EUR	0.0202	0.0378	0.0176
401-500 EUR	0.0292	0.0359	0.0067
501-600 EUR	0.0398	0.0580	0.0182
601-700 EUR	0.0401	0.0804	0.0403**
701-800 EUR	0.0994	0.1340	0.0346
801-900 EUR	0.1152	0.0696	-0.0457*
901-1000 EUR	0.1136	0.1530	0.0394
1001-1200 EUR	0.1903	0.1916	0.0013
1201-1500 EUR	0.2205	0.1480	-0.0725**
1501-2000 EUR	0.0874	0.0604	-0.0270
Above 2000 EUR	0.0442	0.0314	-0.0128
Registered to Vote	0.2389	0.0536	-0.1853***

Notes: The table compares the characteristics of Romanian immigrants who arrived in Italy between 2004–2006 and those who arrived between 2007–2010, after Romania's accession to the EU. The data come from the a WIIW survey of Romanian immigrants in major Italian cities (Milan, Turin and Rome) from before and after the EU Accession. We apply the national weights provided by WIIW to present nationally representative statistics.

Table A.4: Summary Statistics

Variable	Period	#Obs	Mean	Std. Dev.	Min	Max
Share of Romanian Population	2003	7,861	0.003	0.006	0	0.167
Share of Albanian Population	2003	7,861	0.005	0.008	0	0.126
Share of Moroccan Population	2003	7,861	0.006	0.010	0	0.148
Has Romanian-born Councilor	1986–2020	273,961	0.002	0.042	0	1
Has Albanian Councilor	1986–2020	273,961	0.001	0.027	0	1
Has Moroccan Councilor	1986–2020	273,961	0.001	0.028	0	1
Romanian Donors per Municipality	2003–2018	128,205	0.009	0.112	0	7
Albanian Donors per Municipality	2003–2018	128,205	0.004	0.071	0	4
Moroccan Donors per Municipality	2003–2018	128,205	0.002	0.045	0	5
Native Donors per Municipality	2003–2018	128,205	2.650	11.884	0	896
Right-Leaning Mayor	2003–2020	138,080	0.095	0.293	0	1
Left-Leaning Mayor	2003–2020	138,080	0.137	0.343	0	1
Centrist Mayor	2003–2020	138,080	0.013	0.113	0	1
Civic Party Mayor	2003–2020	138,080	0.665	0.472	0	1
Five Star Movement Mayor	2003–2020	138,080	0.002	0.049	0	1
Revenue Share: Property Tax	2003–2015	99,839	0.713	0.154	0	1
Revenue Share: Waste Tax	2003–2015	99,839	0.287	0.154	0	1
Expenditure Share: Transportation	2003–2020	122,919	0.137	0.096	0	0.961
Expenditure Share: Social Policies	2003–2020	122,919	0.095	0.080	0	0.903
Expenditure Share: Public Security	2003–2020	122,919	0.031	0.025	0	0.571
Expenditure Share: Public Housing	2003–2020	122,919	0.008	0.036	0	0.905
Expenditure Share: Education	2003–2020	122,919	0.095	0.071	0	0.991

Notes: The table displays the summary statistics on the dependent and independent variables used in the analyses throughout the paper. Unit of analysis: municipality by year.

Table A.5: Summary statistics. Full sample and subsample with candidates, municipality-by-election level

	Full Sample					
	count	mean	sd	p50	min	max
Population	25267	7390	42132	2422	30	2617175
Share foreigners (Top counties)	25267	0.015	0.017	0.009	0.000	0.213
Share non-Moroccan top muslim countries	25267	0.003	0.006	0.000	0.000	0.146
Share Romanians citizens	25267	0.013	0.017	0.008	0.000	0.433
Share Albanian citizens	25267	0.006	0.010	0.002	0.000	0.185
Share Moroccan citizens	25267	0.008	0.012	0.004	0.000	0.170
Has elected councillor, remaining top counties	25267	0.005	0.074	0.000	0.000	1.000
Has elected councillor, Romanian	25267	0.002	0.049	0.000	0.000	1.000
Has elected councillor, Albanian	25267	0.001	0.032	0.000	0.000	1.000
Has elected councillor, Moroccan	25267	0.001	0.033	0.000	0.000	1.000
	Subsample					
Population	998	12027	34875	3416	58	371337
Share foreigners (Top counties)	998	0.018	0.016	0.013	0.000	0.105
Share non-Moroccan top Muslim countries	998	0.004	0.008	0.001	0.000	0.084
Share Romanians citizens	998	0.015	0.015	0.010	0.000	0.106
Share Albanian citizens	998	0.008	0.010	0.005	0.000	0.074
Share Moroccan citizens	998	0.011	0.012	0.007	0.000	0.131
Has elected councilor, remaining top counties	998	0.009	0.095	0.000	0.000	1.000
Has elected councilor, Romanian	998	0.009	0.095	0.000	0.000	1.000
Has elected councilor, Albanian	998	0.006	0.077	0.000	0.000	1.000
Has elected councilor, Moroccan	998	0.003	0.055	0.000	0.000	1.000
Has candidate councilor, remaining top counties	998	0.080	0.272	0.000	0.000	1.000
Has candidate councilor, top Muslim countries	998	0.026	0.159	0.000	0.000	1.000
Has candidate councilor, Romanian	998	0.095	0.294	0.000	0.000	1.000
Has candidate councilor, Albanian	998	0.064	0.245	0.000	0.000	1.000
Has candidate councilor, Moroccan	998	0.049	0.216	0.000	0.000	1.000

Notes: The table above reports the demographic and political characteristics of municipalities in our sample, that is between 2003-2018. The *full sample* panel reports each municipality in each election year. The *restricted sample* panel reports only the subsample of 333 municipalities for which we obtained the name and place of birth on non-elected candidates in at least one election before and one election after EU accession.

Table A.6: Political Representation (Pooled)

Dep var: presence of councilor born in	(1) Romania	(2) Romania	(3) Albania	(4) Albania	(5) Morocco	(6) Morocco
Romanian share in 2003 × 1998-2002 cycle	**0.012**	**-0.009**	0.033	0.036	0.018	0.030
	(0.016)	(0.016)	(0.021)	(0.030)	(0.036)	(0.028)
Romanian share in 2003 × 2008-2012 cycle	**0.315****	**0.258***	0.022	0.010	-0.049	-0.005
	(0.137)	(0.141)	(0.041)	(0.045)	(0.033)	(0.016)
Romanian share in 2003 × 2013-2017 cycle	**0.508*****	**0.455****	-0.003	-0.007	-0.054	0.011
	(0.182)	(0.206)	(0.029)	(0.035)	(0.049)	(0.041)
Romanian share in 2003 × 2018-2020 cycle	**0.882*****	**0.909*****	-0.080	-0.071	-0.040	-0.017
	(0.298)	(0.340)	(0.070)	(0.081)	(0.063)	(0.050)
Albanian share in 2003 × 1998-2002 cycle	-0.043	-0.060	**-0.034**	**-0.041**	-0.021	-0.021
	(0.029)	(0.040)	(0.025)	(0.029)	(0.027)	(0.026)
Albanian share in 2003 × 2008-2012 cycle	0.011	0.031	**0.084**	**0.110**	-0.004	-0.025
	(0.050)	(0.056)	(0.072)	(0.094)	(0.027)	(0.032)
Albanian share in 2003 × 2013-2017 cycle	0.003	0.068	**0.139****	**0.123**	0.029	0.008
	(0.100)	(0.114)	(0.069)	(0.083)	(0.058)	(0.061)
Albanian share in 2003 × 2018-2020 cycle	-0.059	-0.054	**0.578*****	**0.531*****	0.072	0.052
	(0.134)	(0.147)	(0.175)	(0.184)	(0.066)	(0.062)
Moroccan share in 2003 × 1998-2002 cycle	0.005	0.006	0.027	0.025	**-0.002**	**0.005**
	(0.008)	(0.019)	(0.021)	(0.019)	(0.018)	(0.011)
Moroccan share in 2003 × 2008-2012 cycle	0.048	0.041	-0.028	-0.018	**0.009**	**-0.003**
	(0.048)	(0.048)	(0.021)	(0.017)	(0.010)	(0.012)
Moroccan share in 2003 × 2013-2017 cycle	0.023	0.002	-0.058**	-0.031	**0.090***	**0.042**
	(0.066)	(0.077)	(0.025)	(0.020)	(0.050)	(0.040)
Moroccan share in 2003 × 2018-2020 cycle	0.041	0.045	-0.026	-0.027	**0.267*****	**0.136****
	(0.092)	(0.095)	(0.063)	(0.059)	(0.076)	(0.065)
Municipality FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Year FE	✓		✓		✓	
Province × Year FE		✓		✓		✓
N	177,438	177,438	177,438	177,438	177,438	177,438
Dep var mean	0.002	0.002	0.001	0.001	0.001	0.001
Adj. R^2	0.225	0.227	0.183	0.190	0.250	0.251

Notes: The table reports coefficients on the interaction terms between the share of Romanian, Albanian, and Moroccan residents in a municipality in 2003 and dummy variables for each electoral cycle. The dependent variable is an indicator equal to 1 if, in a given year, the municipality has at least one councilor born in the specified country of origin. The regressions include the sets of fixed effects shown in the table. The omitted electoral cycle is 2003–2007. Standard errors clustered at the municipality level are reported in parentheses. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Table A.7: Likelihood of Electing a Romanian-Born Councilor in Competitive Elections

	(1) Romanian-born Councilor	(2) Albanian-born Councilor	(3) Moroccan-born Councilor
Romanian incumbent councilor	0.028	-0.018	-0.001*
	(0.071)	(0.011)	(0.001)
Albanian incumbent councilor	-0.003	-0.281***	-0.001
	(0.002)	(0.014)	(0.001)
Moroccan incumbent councilor	-0.001	-0.003*	-0.037
	(0.001)	(0.002)	(0.084)
Competitive election t-1	0.001	-0.001	-0.002
	(0.004)	(0.002)	(0.002)
2003 Romanian share × cycle 1998-2002	**0.637**	0.031	-0.085
× competitive	**(0.683)**	(0.131)	(0.137)
2003 Romanian share × cycle 2008-2012	**0.419**	0.398	0.024
× competitive	**(0.763)**	(0.396)	(0.064)
2003 Romanian share × cycle 2013-2017	**2.027****	-0.047	0.416
× competitive	**(1.021)**	(0.135)	(0.288)
2003 Romanian share × cycle 2018-2020	**1.392**	0.138	0.475
× competitive	**(1.563)**	(0.333)	(0.378)
2003 Albanian share × cycle 1998-2002	0.161	**0.365***	-0.167
× competitive	(0.349)	**(0.197)**	(0.102)
2003 Albanian share × cycle 2008-2012	0.249	**0.639**	-0.079
× competitive	(0.404)	**(0.496)**	(0.133)
2003 Albanian share × cycle 2013-2017	-0.098	**-0.098**	-0.728**
× competitive	(0.349)	**(0.257)**	(0.319)
2003 Albanian share × cycle 2018-2020	0.596	**-0.332**	-0.445
× competitive	(0.535)	**(0.578)**	(0.273)
2003 Moroccan share × cycle 1998-2002	-0.229*	0.075	**0.088**
× competitive	(0.118)	(0.116)	**(0.150)**
2003 Moroccan share × cycle 2008-2012	-0.374*	0.004	**0.084**
× competitive	(0.195)	(0.167)	**(0.103)**
2003 Moroccan share × cycle 2013-2017	-0.247	0.070	**0.672**
× competitive	(0.329)	(0.136)	**(0.431)**
2003 Moroccan share × cycle 2018-2020	-0.960***	0.352	**0.020**
× competitive	(0.340)	(0.323)	**(0.477)**
Municipality FE	✓	✓	✓
Electoral Cycle FE	✓	✓	✓
Observations	29,859	29,859	29,859
Adj. R2	0.084	0.022	0.038

Notes: The table reports the coefficients on the triple interaction terms from Equation 5. The dependent variable is an indicator equal to 1 if, in a given year, a municipality has at least one councilor born in the specified origin country. Competitive is an indicator equal to 1 if the previous election was decided by a margin of 5% or less. Double interaction terms are omitted for readability. The omitted electoral cycle is 2003–2007. Standard errors clustered at the municipality level are reported in parentheses. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Table A.8: Political Orientation of Romanian-born Councilors

	Non-Romanian-born			Romanian-born			
	N	Mean	SD	N	Mean	SD	Difference
Winning party	790030	0.60	0.49	265	0.68	0.47	0.083***
Civic	1326900	0.74	0.44	369	0.72	0.45	-0.021
Center	1326900	0.01	0.11	369	0.01	0.07	-0.007
Left	1326900	0.12	0.32	369	0.12	0.33	0.007
Right	1326900	0.10	0.30	369	0.11	0.32	0.017
Winning party(year<2014)	268089	0.44	0.50	53	0.30	0.46	-0.137**

Notes: The table above reports summary statistics of the partisan affiliation of the elected councilors. The last row reports statistics on the Romanian and non-Romanian-born councilors who were elected before 2014 and were members of the winning party or coalition in their municipality. Unit of analysis: municipality-by-party-by-year (lines 1 and 6) municipality-by-councilor-by-year (lines 2-5).

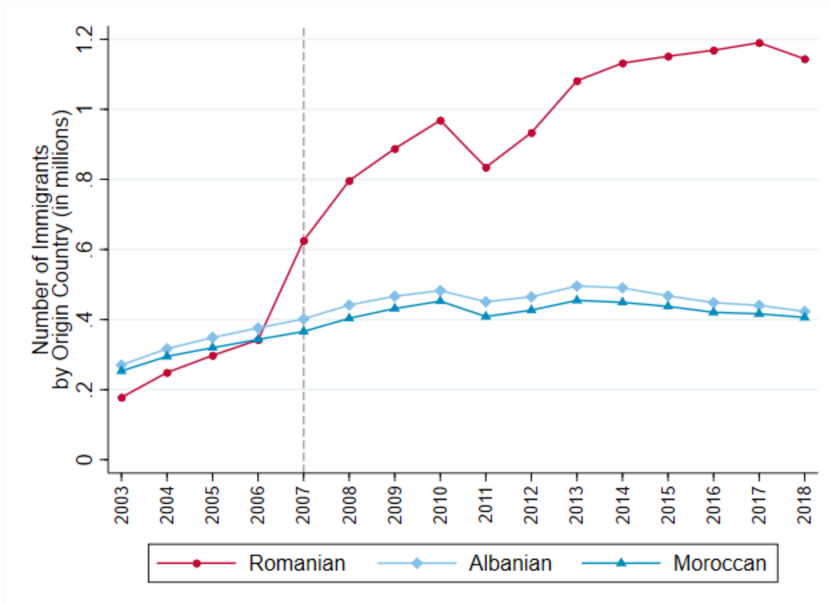
Table A.9: Consents to Organ Donation, IV and Consents as a Share of Immigrant Population

	(1) OLS	(2) OLS	(3) 2SLS	(4) 2SLS	(5) OLS	(6) OLS	(7) 2SLS	(8) 2SLS
Dependent Variable:	Count of new Romanian donors				Share of new Romanian donors			
Romanian share in 2003	0.4088***		5.4535***		0.0058**		0.0291**	
× Post2007	(0.0988)		(0.8830)		(0.0026)		(0.0142)	
Early Romanian Share		0.1320		-0.1146		-0.0061		-0.0080
		(0.0930)		(0.3714)		(0.0038)		(0.0071)
Early Romanian Share		0.3279***		3.7325***		0.0054**		0.0230**
× Post2007		(0.0968)		(0.5599)		(0.0024)		(0.0111)
New Romanian Inflow	0.1185***	0.0916**	-6.6240***	-5.9346***	-0.0001	-0.0003	-0.0326*	-0.0319*
	(0.0390)	(0.0332)	(1.2355)	(1.0743)	(0.0014)	(0.0018)	(0.0183)	(0.0180)
Municipality FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Obs	115,887	115,897	115,887	115,897	104,686	104,696	104,686	104,696
Dep var mean	0.009	0.009	0.009	0.009	0.00014	0.00014	0.00014	0.00014

Notes: Columns (1)-(4) from the table above present the OLS and 2SLS specifications of Equation (6) when using as an outcome the number of new Romanian consents expressed each year. Columns (5)-(8) show the OLS and 2SLS specifications of Equation (6) when using as an outcome the share of new Romanian consents over the number of Romanians. Columns (1), (2), (5), (6) report the the OLS results, while columns (3), (4), (7), (8) show the 2SLS estimates that correspond to the first stage reported in columns (1) and (2) of Table 1. Standard errors clustered by municipality in parentheses. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

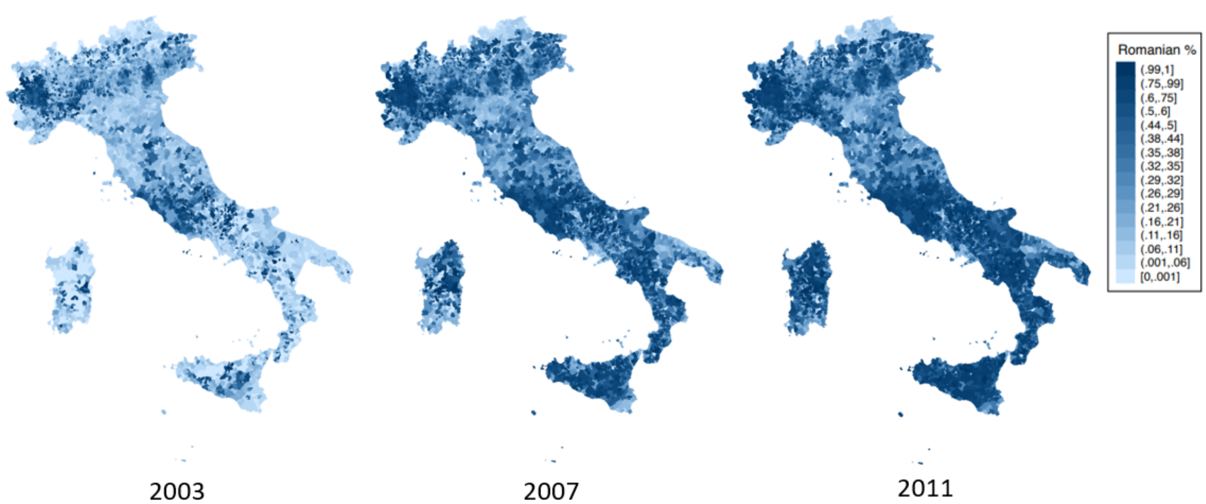
Appendix Figures

Figure A.1: Number of Foreign Nationals Living in Italy by Nationality



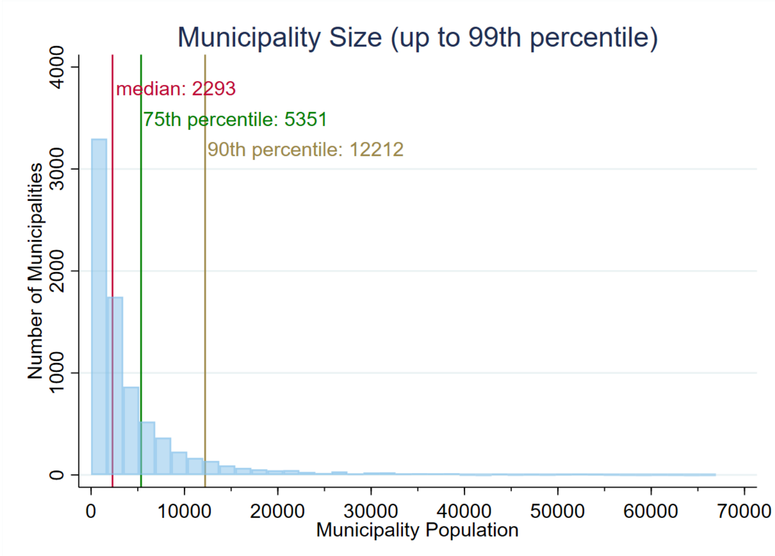
Notes: The figure shows the yearly evolution of the number of foreign nationals in Italy by nationality from 2003 to 2018. (Source: ISTAT)

Figure A.2: Share of Romanians Among Immigrants by Municipality and Year



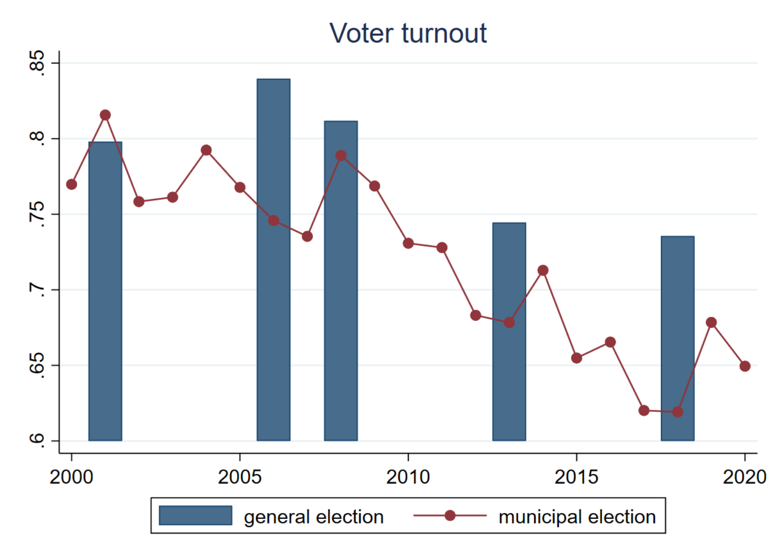
Notes: The maps above display the number of Romanians as a fraction of total immigrants within a given municipality in years 2003, 2007, and 2011 respectively.

Figure A.3: Distribution of Municipality Population



Notes: The graph above shows the distribution of municipal population sizes for all municipalities up to the 99th percentile at the beginning of our sample. The median municipality has 2,293 residents. (Source: 2001 Italian Census)

Figure A.4: Turnout for General vs. Municipal Elections in Italy

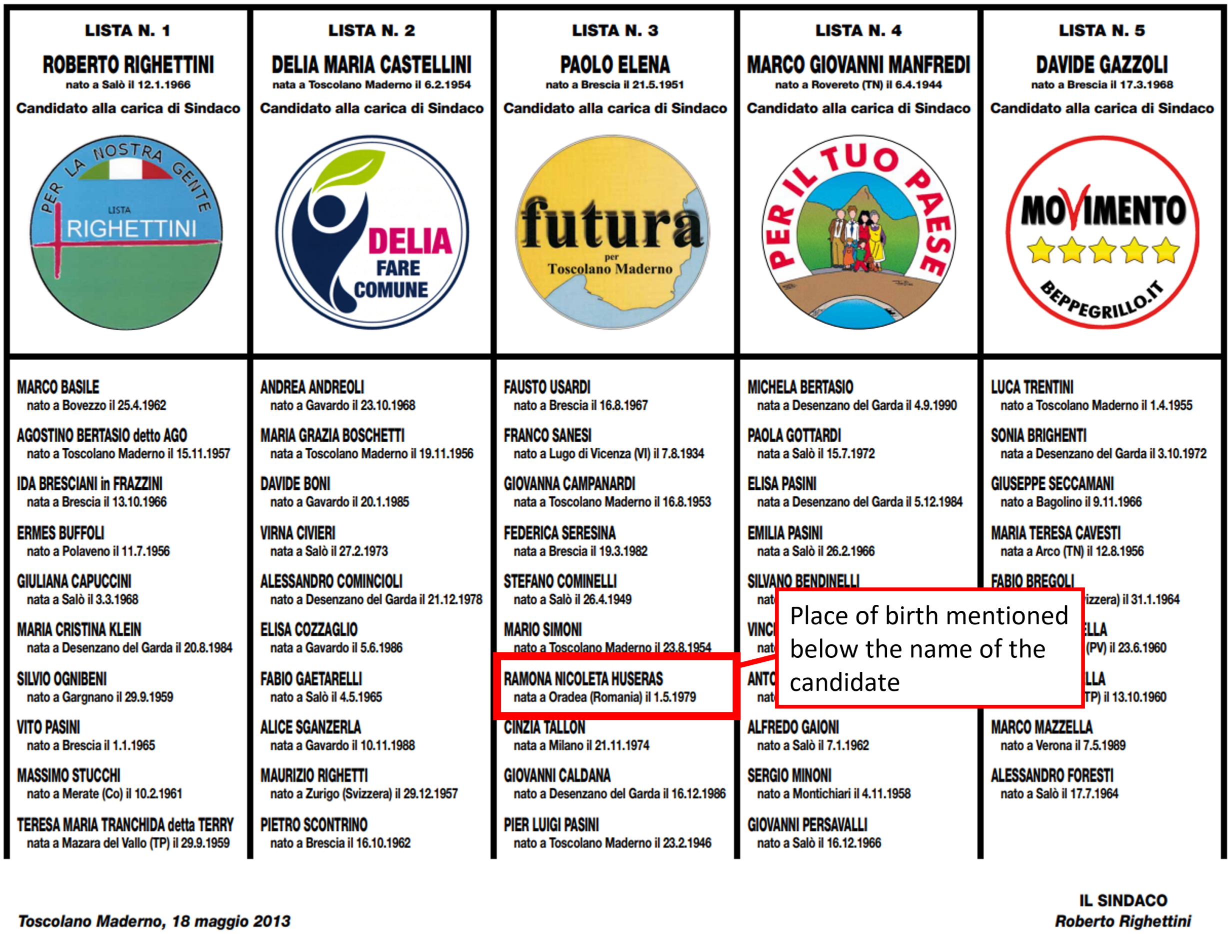


The graph above compares the turnout for general vs. municipal elections in Italy. (Source: Ministry of Interior of Italy)

Figure A.5: Municipalities with at least a Romanian-born Councilor, pre- and post-2007

Notes: This map illustrates the municipalities with at least one Romanian-born councilor in the period 2003-2007 or in the period 2008-2020, respectively.

Figure A.6: Roster of Candidates in a Municipal Election



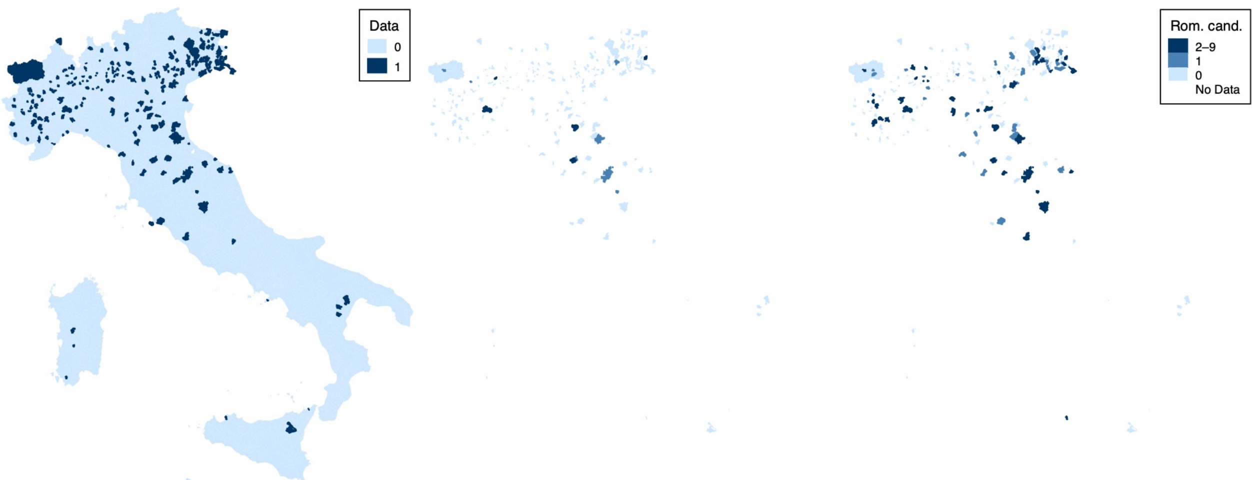
LISTA N. 1	LISTA N. 2	LISTA N. 3	LISTA N. 4	LISTA N. 5
ROBERTO RIGHETTINI nato a Salò il 12.1.1966 Candidato alla carica di Sindaco	**DELIA MARIA CASTELLINI** nata a Toscolano Maderno il 6.2.1954 Candidato alla carica di Sindaco	**PAOLO ELENA** nato a Brescia il 21.5.1951 Candidato alla carica di Sindaco	**MARCO GIOVANNI MANFREDI** nato a Rovereto (TN) il 6.4.1944 Candidato alla carica di Sindaco	**DAVIDE GAZZOLI** nato a Brescia il 17.3.1968 Candidato alla carica di Sindaco
MARCO BASILE nato a Bovezzo il 25.4.1962	**ANDREA ANDREOLI** nato a Gavardo il 23.10.1968	**FAUSTO USARDI** nato a Brescia il 16.8.1967	**MICHELA BERTASIO** nata a Desenzano del Garda il 4.9.1990	**LUCA TRENTINI** nato a Toscolano Maderno il 1.4.1955
AGOSTINO BERTASIO detto AGO nato a Toscolano Maderno il 15.11.1957	**MARIA GRAZIA BOSCHETTI** nata a Toscolano Maderno il 19.11.1956	**FRANCO SANESI** nato a Lugo di Vicenza (VI) il 7.8.1934	**PAOLA GOTTARDI** nata a Salò il 15.7.1972	**SONIA BRIGHENTI** nata a Desenzano del Garda il 3.10.1972
IDA BRESCIANI in FRAZZINI nata a Brescia il 13.10.1966	**DAVIDE BONI** nato a Gavardo il 20.1.1985	**GIOVANNA CAMPANARDI** nata a Toscolano Maderno il 16.8.1953	**ELISA PASINI** nata a Desenzano del Garda il 5.12.1984	**GIUSEPPE SECCAMANI** nato a Bagolino il 9.11.1966
ERMES BUFFOLI nato a Polaveno il 11.7.1956	**VIRNA CIVIERI** nata a Salò il 27.2.1973	**FEDERICA SERESINA** nata a Brescia il 19.3.1982	**EMILIA PASINI** nata a Salò il 26.2.1966	**MARIA TERESA CAVESTI** nata a Arco (TN) il 12.8.1956
GIULIANA CAPUCCINI nata a Salò il 3.3.1968	**ALESSANDRO COMINCIOLI** nato a Desenzano del Garda il 21.12.1978	**STEFANO COMINELLI** nato a Salò il 26.4.1949	**SILVANO BENDINELLI** nat	**FABIO BREGOLI** izzera) il 31.1.1964
MARIA CRISTINA KLEIN nata a Desenzano del Garda il 20.8.1984	**ELISA COZZAGLIO** nata a Gavardo il 5.6.1986	**MARIO SIMONI** nato a Toscolano Maderno il 23.8.1954	**VINC** nat	**LLA** (PV) il 23.6.1960
SILVIO OGNIBENI nato a Gargnano il 29.9.1959	**FABIO GAETARELLI** nato a Salò il 4.5.1965	**RAMONA NICOLETA HUSERAS** nata a Oradea (Romania) il 1.5.1979	**ANTO** nat	**LLA** TP) il 13.10.1960
VITO PASINI nato a Brescia il 1.1.1965	**ALICE SGANZERLA** nata a Gavardo il 10.11.1988	**CINZIA TALLON** nata a Milano il 21.11.1974	**ALFREDO GAIONI** nato a Salò il 7.1.1962	**MARCO MAZZELLA** nato a Verona il 7.5.1989
MASSIMO STUCCHI nato a Merate (Co) il 10.2.1961	**MAURIZIO RIGHETTI** nato a Zurigo (Svizzera) il 29.12.1957	**GIOVANNI CALDANA** nato a Desenzano del Garda il 16.12.1986	**SERGIO MINONI** nato a Montichiari il 4.11.1958	**ALESSANDRO FORESTI** nato a Salò il 17.7.1964
TERESA MARIA TRANCHIDA detta TERRY nata a Mazara del Vallo (TP) il 29.9.1959	**PIETRO SCONTRINO** nato a Brescia il 16.10.1962	**PIER LUIGI PASINI** nato a Toscolano Maderno il 23.2.1946	**GIOVANNI PERSAVALLI** nato a Salò il 16.12.1966	

Toscolano Maderno, 18 maggio 2013

IL SINDACO
Roberto Righettini

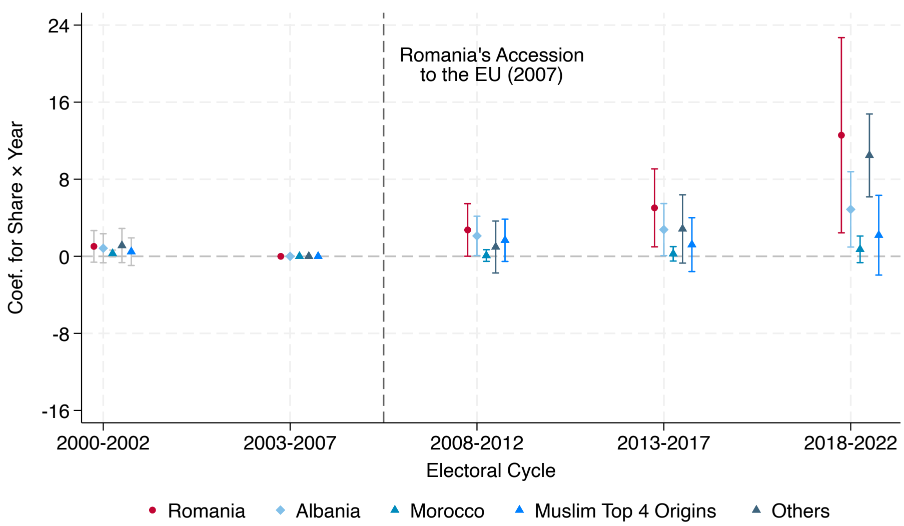
The figure shows an example roster from a municipal election in Italy. The roster contains the name, birthplace, and date of birth of all candidates, as well as their party affiliation.

Figure A.7: Candidates sample: coverage; candidates pre-2008; post-2007



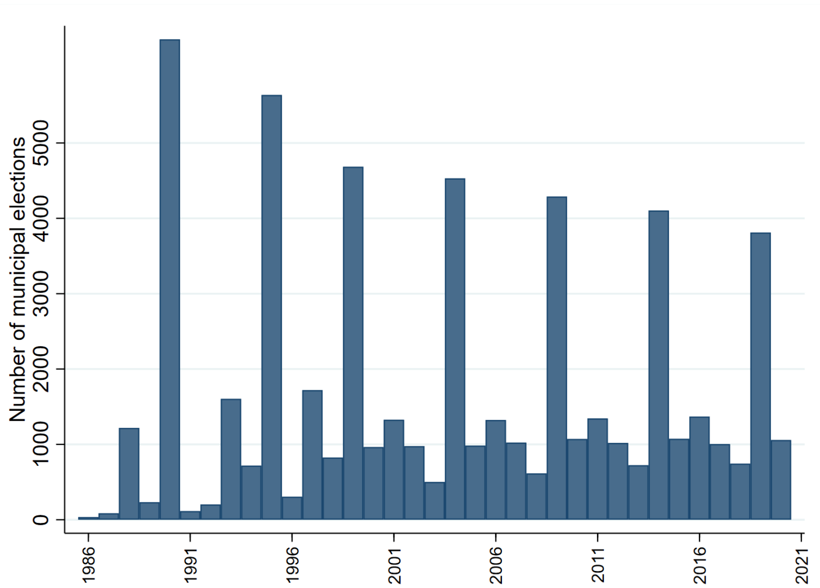
Notes: This map illustrates the coverage of our data collection on municipal candidates. The sample includes 333 municipalities that responded to our requests and provided data with at least one complete electoral roster prior to 2008 and two complete rosters after 2008. The left panel presents overall coverage, while the middle and right panels restrict attention to covered municipalities and display the number of Romanian-born candidates before and after 2008, respectively.

Figure A.8: Likelihood of having Candidate born in Origin Country O, by Municipal Share of Citizens from O, adding data with inferred origins from Trentino-Alto Adige



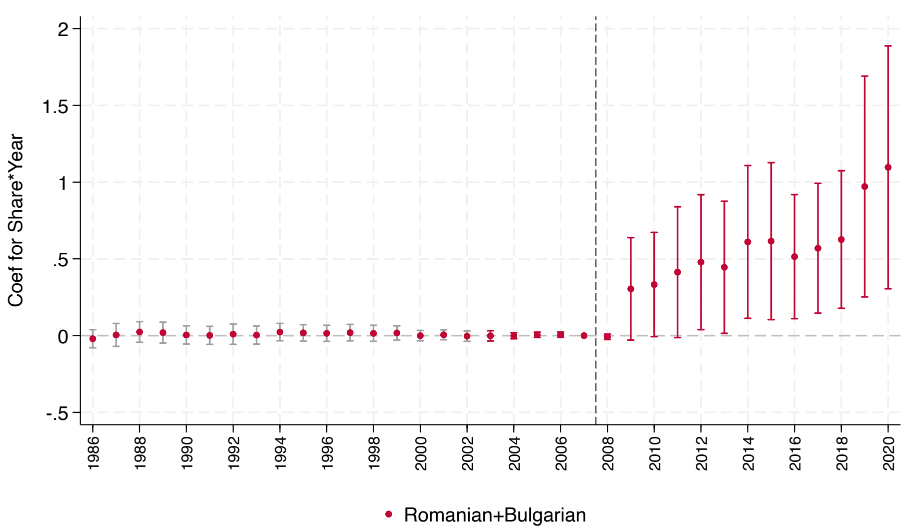
Notes: The graph above plots the coefficients from the event study where the years are collapsed to the corresponding electoral cycles. The plotted coefficients are for the interaction terms between Immigrants' share fixed at its 2003 level and cycle dummies. The dependent variable is an indicator variable equal to 1 when the given municipality has a Romanian-born, Albanian-born or Moroccan-born candidate in the given year and 0 otherwise. The regression separately controls for municipality and year fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the municipality level. Sample: 333 municipalities for which we have place of birth plus all the 343 municipalities of Trentino and Alto-Adige, for which we have only names. We assign Romanian origin (but not Albanian or Moroccan) based on names using Ethnea as discussed in Footnote 21. Bars represent 95 percent confidence intervals.

Figure A.9: Municipal Election Cycle



Notes: The graph above displays the number of municipal elections that took place in each year from 1986 to 2020. Although the municipal election cycle is asynchronous, the majority of municipalities hold their election during the biggest cycle.

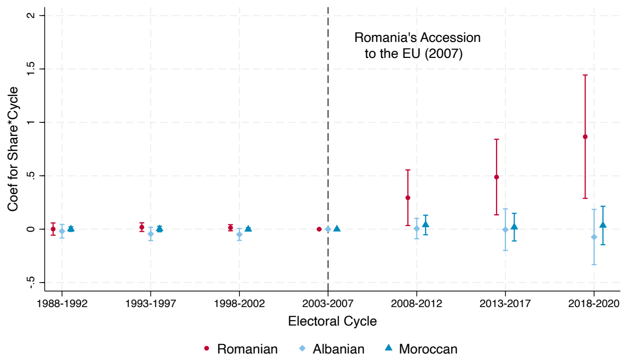
Figure A.10: Combined Political Representation of Romanians and Bulgarians vs Combined Romanian and Bulgarian Share Fixed at the 2003 Level



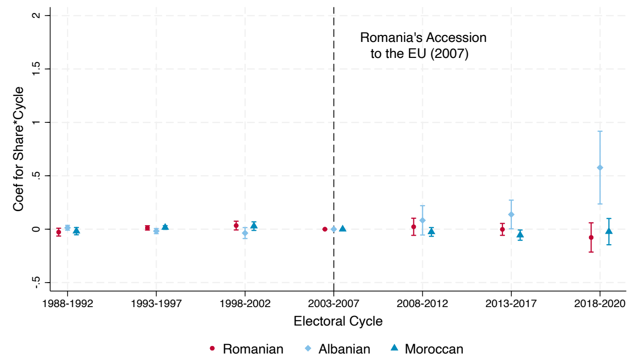
Notes: Identical specification as in Figure 2. The relevant immigrant group (both in terms of councilors and municipal population) now pools Romanian and Bulgarian together. Bars represent 95 percent confidence intervals.

Figure A.11: Likelihood of Having a Councilor of Specified Origin by Presence of Different Immigrant Shares

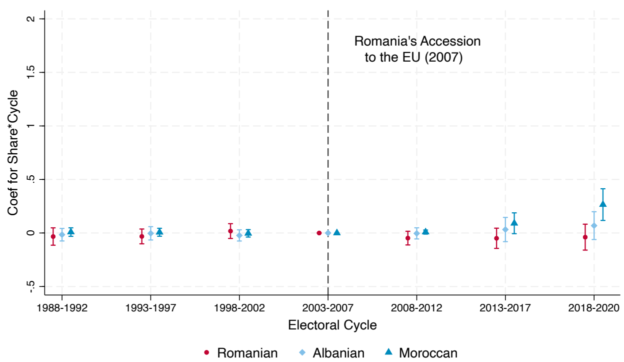
(a) Romanian-born councilor



(b) Albanian-born councilor

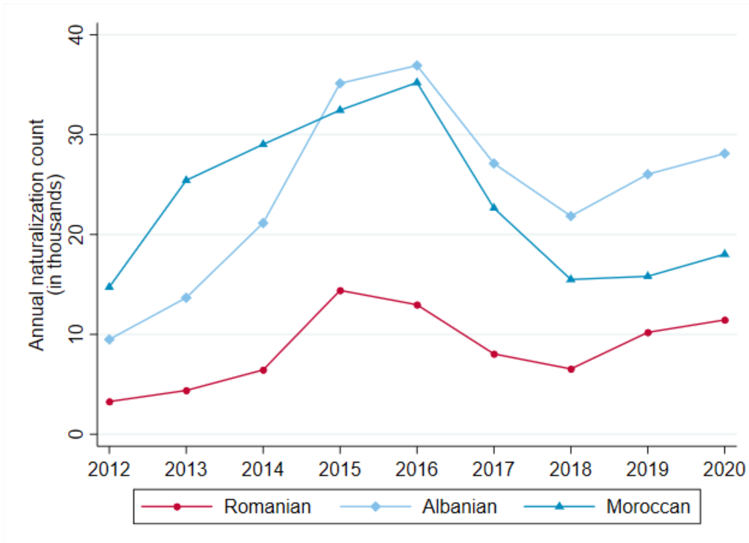


(c) Moroccan-born councilor



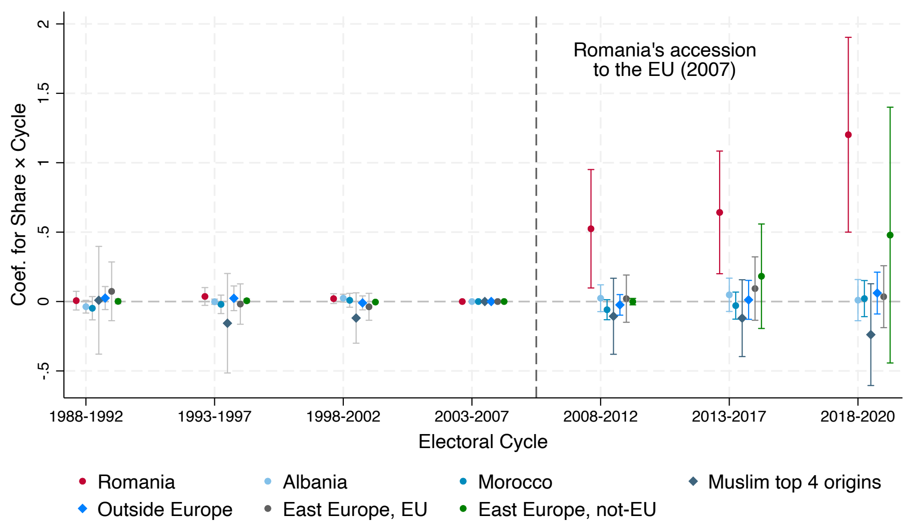
Notes: The graphs above plot the coefficients from the event study for the interaction terms between immigrant shares fixed at their 2003 level and the year dummies, as described in Equation 1. The dependent variable is an indicator variable equal to 1 when the given municipality has a councilor of the specified origin in the given year and 0 otherwise. For instance, panel (a) shows the coefficients from a single regression where the outcome is the election of a Romanian-born councilor and the left hand side includes interaction terms between year dummies and Romanian, Albanian, and Moroccans share, whose coefficient are plotted. Panel (b) is identical but only the dependent variable changes (now, election of an Albanian-born councilor). The regression separately controls for municipality and year fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the municipality level. Bars represent 95 percent confidence intervals.

Figure A.12: Annual Naturalization Count in Italy by Origin Country



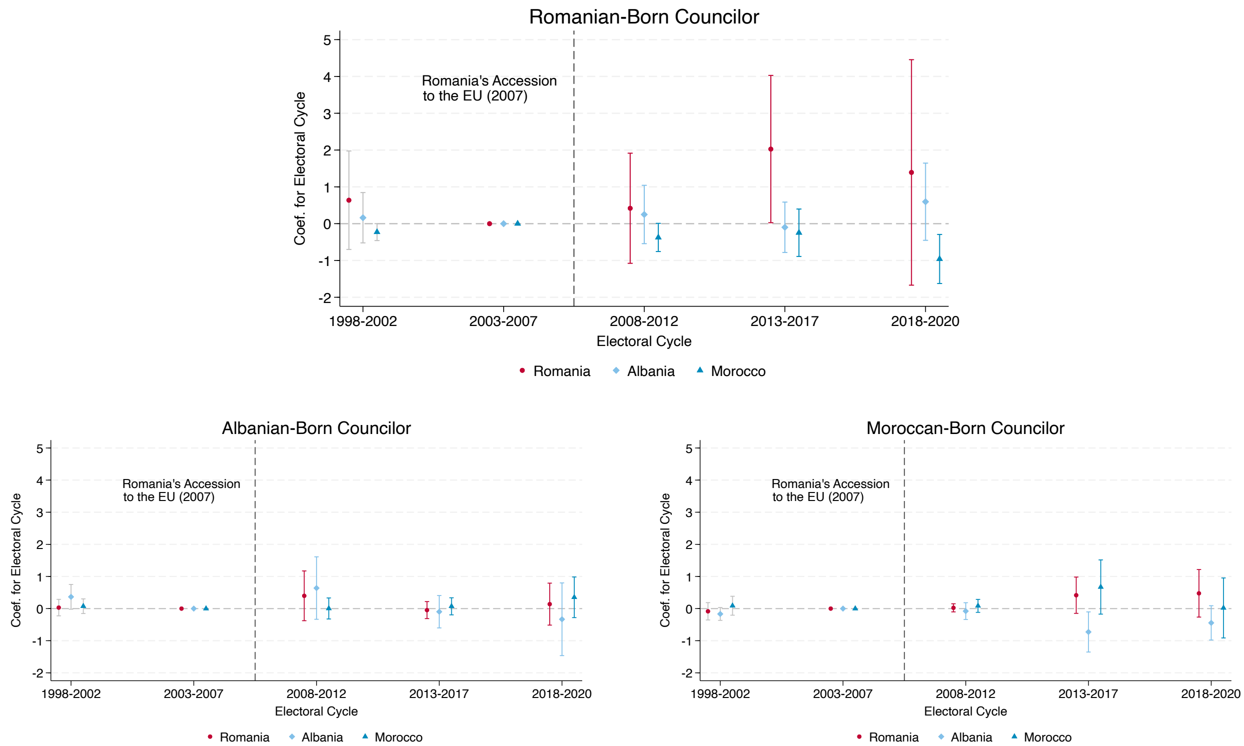
Notes: The graph above displays annual naturalization count in Italy for immigrants from Romania, Albania, and Morocco respectively. No data on naturalization by citizenship of origin available before 2012.

Figure A.13: Who do Romanians vote for? Councilors by different country of birth in municipalities with more Romanians



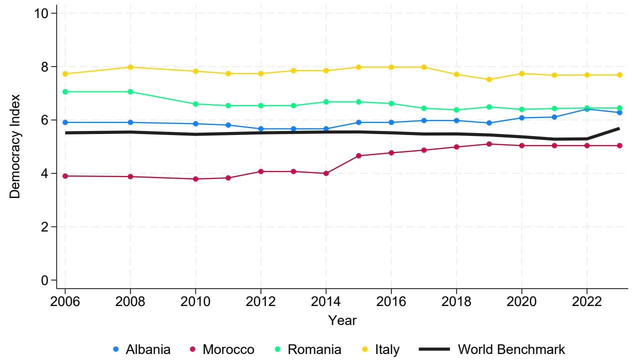
Notes: The graph above plots the coefficients from the event study where the years are collapsed to electoral cycles. The plotted coefficients are for the interaction terms between Romanian share fixed at its 2003 level and cycle dummies. The dependent variable is an indicator variable equal to 1 when the given municipality has a Romanian/Albanian/Moroccan/Top 4 Muslim/Top 18 Others-born councilor in the given year and 0 otherwise. The regression separately controls for municipality and year fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the municipality level. Bars represent 95 percent confidence intervals.

Figure A.14: Close elections and immigrant representation



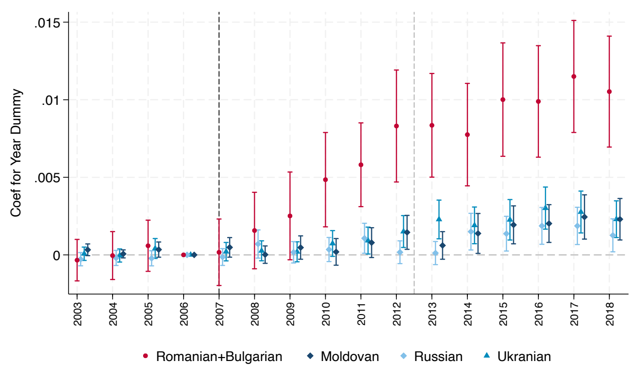
Notes: The graphs above plot coefficients from the triple-difference specification for the interaction terms between immigrant shares fixed at their 2003 level, the cycle dummies, and an indicator for close elections, as shown in Equation (5). The dependent variable is stated above each graph. It is an indicator equal to 1 when the municipality has a councilor who was born in the specific foreign country in the given cycle. In each graph, the coefficients are from a single regression where the main coefficients of interest are those for interaction terms between the immigrant share of interest and cycle dummies, while controlling for the presence of other immigrant communities (as in Figure A.11a). The regression separately controls for municipality and year fixed effects. Bars represent 95 percent confidence intervals.

Figure A.15: Democracy Index



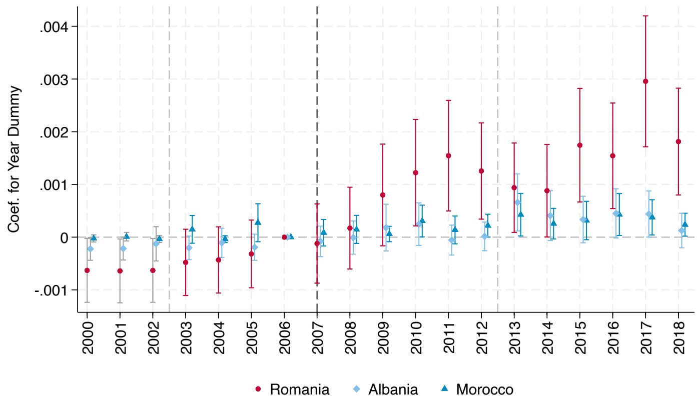
Notes: Source: Economist Intelligence Unit (2006-2023) – processed by Our World in Data. The figure shows the democracy index for the countries of interest. The first index was calculated in 2006, with reports published biennially until 2010 and annually thereafter.

Figure A.16: Comparison of Consent Rate Among Romanian and Bulgarian Immigrants vs. Immigrants from Largest Christian Orthodox Countries



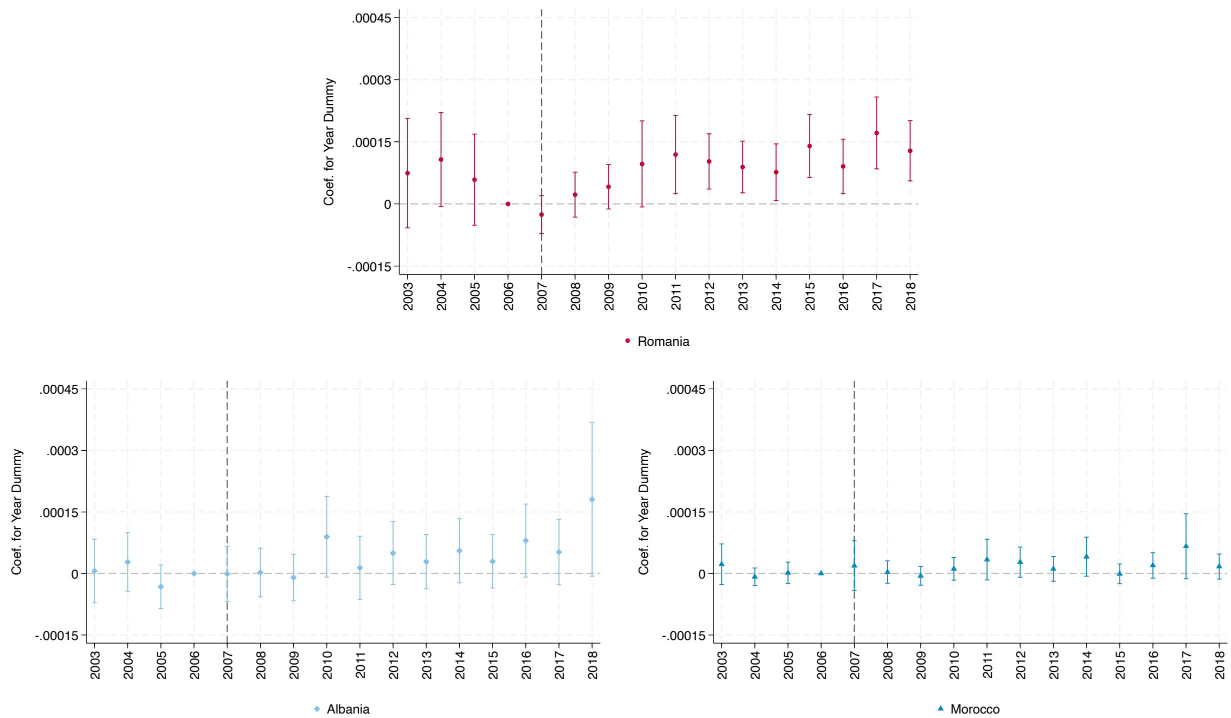
Notes: The figure is identical to Figure 6, but now the reference immigrant groups are Romanians and Bulgarians pooled together (to account for the fact that also Bulgaria joined the EU in 2007), Russians, Ukrainians, Moldovans. No extrapolated data. Bars represent 95 percent confidence intervals.

Figure A.17: Consent to organ donation by by immigrant group as a share of new native donors



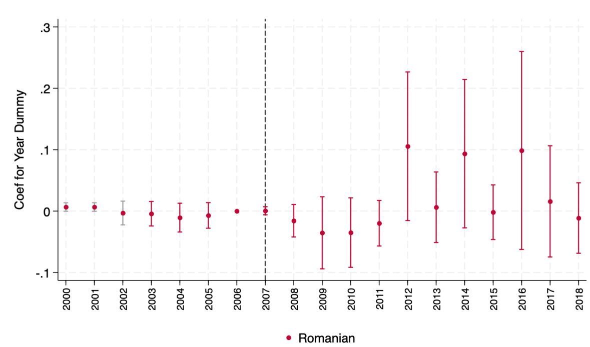
Notes: The figure replicates Figure 6, but replaces the dependent variable, namely the number of Romanian-born individuals giving consent to organ donation, with the ratio of this variable to the number of donors born in Italy. The regression controls for municipality fixed effect. Standard errors are clustered at the municipality level. Bars represent 95 percent confidence intervals.

Figure A.18: New consents to organ donation by immigrant group as a share of group population



Notes: The figure replicates Figure 6, but now the dependent variable is the number of new consents by Romanian-born individuals as a share of municipal Romanian population (rath). Given the need for a well-defined population at risk, the sample is restricted to municipalities with at least ten Romanian (Albanian, Moroccan, respectively) residents prior to Romania's accession to the EU in 2006. No extrapolated data are used. The specification includes municipality fixed effects, and does not control for the Romanian population, as this would constitute a mechanical (bad) control in this setting. Standard errors are clustered at the municipality level. Bars represent 95 percent confidence intervals.

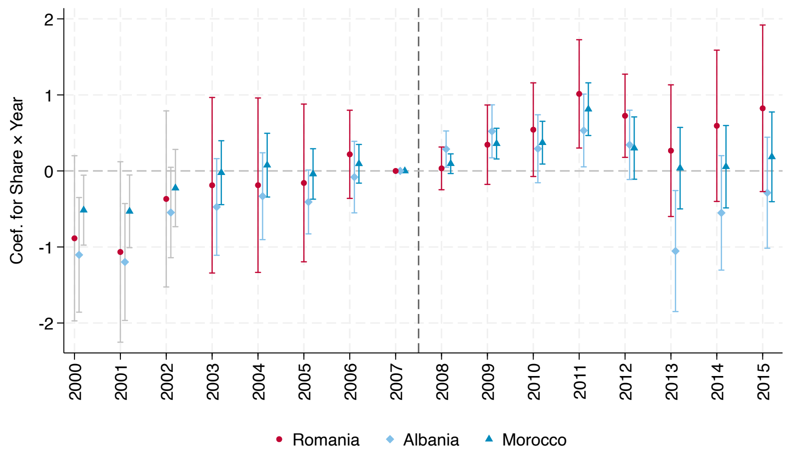
Figure A.19: Consent to Organ Donation by Representation in Council



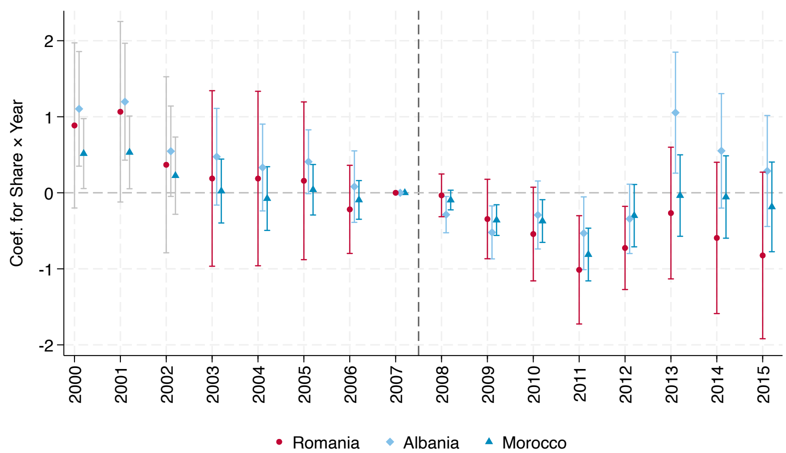
Notes: Outcome variable: number of donations by Romanian-born citizens. The coefficients capture the interaction between year dummies and an indicator for having a Romanian-born councilor. The regression controls for municipality and year fixed effects, respectively. Standard errors are clustered at the municipality level. Bars represent 95 percent confidence intervals.

Figure A.20: Local Tax Revenue Composition

Revenue share: Property tax

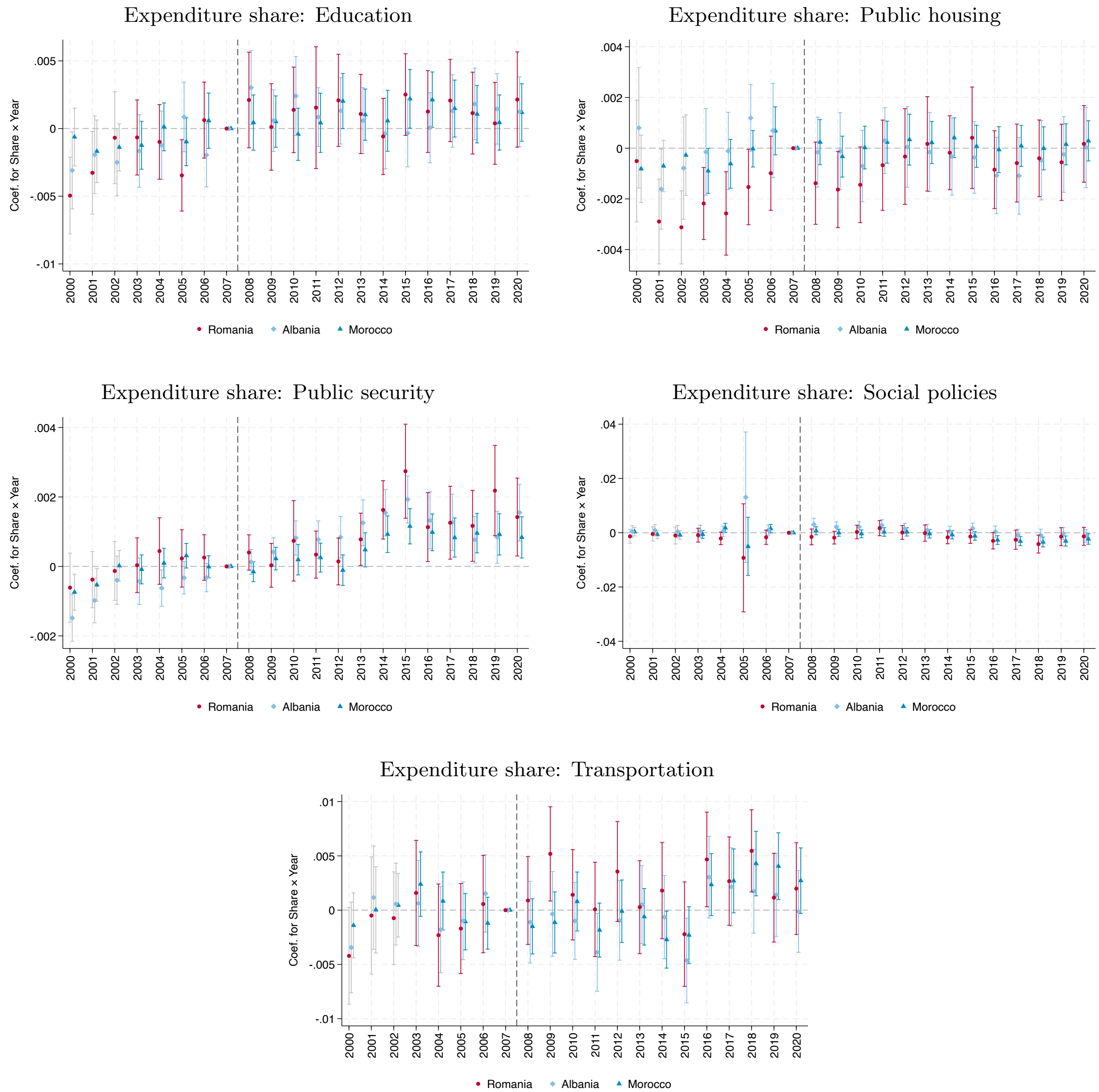


Revenue share: Waste tax



Notes: The graphs above plot the coefficients from the event study for the interaction terms between the immigrant share of interest fixed at its 2003 level and year dummies. The red dot refers to the regression in which the immigrant share of interest is Romanian share whereas the light blue diamond and the blue triangle correspond to separate regressions where the immigrant share of interest is Albanian and Moroccan share respectively. The dependent variable is the tax collection corresponding to the title of the graph as a share of municipal government revenue. The regression separately controls for municipality and year fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the municipality level. Bars represent 95 percent confidence intervals.

Figure A.21: Local Expenditure Breakdown



Notes: The graphs above plot the coefficients from the event study for the interaction terms between the immigrant share of interest fixed at its 2003 level and year dummies. The red dot refers to the regression in which the immigrant share of interest is Romanian share whereas the light blue diamond and the blue triangle correspond to separate regressions where the immigrant share of interest is Albanian and Moroccan share respectively. The dependent variable is the level of spending corresponding to the title of the graph as a share of municipal government total expenditure. The regression separately controls for municipality and year fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the municipality level. Bars represent 95 percent confidence intervals.